

Conclusions

Government Performance, Political Representation, and Public Perceptions of Contemporary Democracy in Latin America

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A quarter century after the Third Wave of democratization began in Latin America, democratic regimes have never been as prevalent or even as secure in Latin America. There have been no reversals of democracy to speak of in the past quarter century – only in Peru in 1992 was there a partial exception to democratic rule, and only in Cuba today is an authoritarian leader so firmly entrenched that uncertainty remains about the way to effect a democratic transition. In most of the continent, that transition took place so long ago that an entire generation cannot remember living at a time when they could not vote for their leaders.

Yet, all is not well. Public support and enthusiasm for democracy is as weak as it has perhaps ever been. When asked specifically whether or not they prefer democracy to any other form of government, Latin Americans manifest high rates of ambivalence. Latinobarómetro data – published annually in *The Economist* magazine – shows that Latin America is replete with “doubting democrats.”¹ On average, in 2003 only slightly more than half of Latin Americans agreed with the statement that “democracy is preferable to any other kind of government” (*The Economist* 2003: 33),² and 52 percent of respondents across the region agreed that they would “not mind a non-democratic government in power if it could solve the economic problems” (Latinobarómetro 2003: 12). Only in Honduras, Venezuela, and Mexico has public support for democracy not eroded in the past seven years (see Table 1.11). Forty-four percent of Paraguayans, a third of Ecuadorians, and about a fifth of Bolivians, Peruvians, Brazilians, Argentines, and Panamanians even went so far as to say that, in certain circumstances, an authoritarian government could be preferable to a democratic one (*The Economist* 2003: 33). If one wonders whether or not to believe polls, and what precisely it means when people aren’t quite sure

¹ A table in one of these published surveys (*The Economist*, 2002) carries the tag, “Still doubting democrats.”

² This average is weighted.

whether they prefer democracy as a political regime type, the trends visible in polls are confirmed by a general rise in electoral abstentions, electoral volatility, and new parties and antisystem political leaders. In the past five years, several elected presidents, among them Jamil Mahuad (Ecuador, 2000), Fernando de la Rúa (Argentina, 2001), Gonzalo Sánchez de Lozada (Bolivia, 2003), and Jean-Bertrand Aristide (Haiti, 2004) were forced by public protests to leave office ahead of the expiration of their terms. In a 2004 report, the United Nations Development Programme warned that after 25 years of progress toward elected civilian government, Latin American democracies are suffering from a deep crisis of confidence (UNDP 2004).

Thus we are faced with a paradox: The military has stayed in its barracks, and civilian elites seem to want to keep them there, yet, support for democracy and its institutions is diminishing. Unlike the 1960s and 1970s, when democracies were weakened by the clash of ordinary people demanding the rights that elites were reluctant to grant – to *become* citizens – today the crisis of democracy in the region is one of the widespread and deep disillusion of those who *are* citizens. Mass disaffection has led to low levels of public trust in political institutions and political parties, to mass support for strong-arm democrats – the “neopopulist” leaders – and even to such popular subversions of the rule of law as mass lynchings.

One could object that mass satisfaction or disaffection with democracy does not matter, and anyone interested in projecting the future stability of democracy in Latin America should look elsewhere. Yet, democracy in the Third Wave of democratization is a broader affair than was democracy in the second, postwar wave of democratization, when many observers feel that democracies broke down precisely because they could not handle – either structurally or institutionally – the demands for redistribution and a share of political power that emanated from the popular classes. The political rights of citizenship – in particular voting rights – have expanded since the 1960s. Illiterates won the vote in Chile in 1970, in Peru in 1980, and in Brazil in 1985.³ Indeed, the electorate expanded considerably in most of the countries included in this volume. Mass democracy today carries with it a set of demands on government that are greater than ever before.

Skeptics could also rightfully claim, moreover, that democracies in Latin America are not the only ones that are “troubled,” and our paradox is not unique to the region. If citizens in Latin America are worried about unemployment and corruption and the quality of health care and education, and they vote

³ To give a sense of the immediate impact of this reform, in Chile, those voting as a percentage of the *voting age population* rose from 46 percent in the 1969 parliamentary election to 63 percent in the 1973 election. In Peru, the percentage of those voting in presidential elections rose from 36 percent in 1973 to 59 percent in 1980 to 73 percent in 1985. In Brazil, 33 percent of the voting age population cast a ballot for president in 1960, compared to 79 percent in 1989. Data are from the Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance (IDEA): http://www.idea.int/voter_turnout/southamerica/chile.html; http://www.idea.int/voter_turnout/southamerica/peru.html; http://www.idea.int/voter_turnout/southamerica/brazil.html.

on that basis – if they are “critical” – then this makes them pretty much like citizens elsewhere, as one recent book title, *Critical Citizens* (Norris 1999), implies. In fact, citizens around the world do defer to and trust their governments less. Democracies in the former communist bloc have seen increases in citizen disaffection as the memory of communism fades, unemployment rises, and social services decline. Moreover, not merely new democracies, but established democracies, too, seem to be afflicted, as attested to by one prominent recent volume – *Disaffected Democracies* (Pharr and Putnam 2000). Yet, even with this important caveat, levels of public support for democracy are far lower in the newer Latin American democracies than in the established democracies of the Trilateral region, and skepticism about government in the Trilateral countries has not produced the same degree of regime instability.

This chapter takes up the question of why, on the one hand, democracy has survived so well for so long, even in the far reaches of the continent where it has no roots, and why, on the other, such pessimism about democracy and its prospects abounds. Why support for democracy is declining is not an easy question to answer. Our sense of “strong” and “fragile” democracies shifts quickly, making it difficult to draw conclusions and establish causal patterns. Drawing from the collective wisdom of the authors of the chapters in this volume, I contend that the same factors that keep political regimes safe – such as international support for democracy and value change, or even the proper functioning of political institutions that can overcome the constraints of divided government and fragmented party systems – are not enough to ensure citizen support for democracy. To explain democracy’s erosion, we must move beyond the paradigms on which we have largely relied in our studies of regime transition and democratization. Many scholars, including Scott Mainwaring and Aníbal Pérez-Liñán in this volume, have forcefully argued that the performance of democratic governments, specifically to generate jobs, reduce poverty and inequality, and establish the rule of law, has been woefully inadequate where democratic regimes have tottered. I build on this insight and connect it to a second theme that recurs throughout this volume: the importance of the expectations, participation, and political representation of citizens in stabilizing democracy. Whether or not governments perform well, citizens must *perceive* that their elected leaders are governing in a clean, transparent, and effective way, and above all, that their voices are being heard.

My thesis is that in an era of mass democracy, these perceptions – both of what citizens expect as well as what their political leaders deliver – often depend critically on the functioning of the institutions of political representation. Where institutions of political representation are vibrant, and where parties are responsive and accountable to the preferences of citizens that can associate in the terrain of civil and political society, democracy is somewhat inoculated from setbacks, even when banking systems collapse and corruption scandals are brought to light. But where these channels have decayed and do not function well, or civil society is strong but political institutions are weak, antisystem leaders may successfully mobilize support, and the future is far more uncertain.

Of course the crucial question that this analysis raises, but I do not pretend to answer in this chapter, is whether democracy can continue to survive without popular support. Mainwaring and Pérez-Liñán analyze the impact of other variables on the survivability to date of democratic regimes, but the world of mass public opinion is a brave new one. Absent hard data that would permit us to test empirically past patterns, and dependent only on historical accounts and passing observations of the public mood, the past may, or may not, be an accurate guide to the future.

I proceed as follows. First, I attempt to summarize what we have learned about democracy's advance. Next, I map out where – in what countries and in what areas – we see signs of vitality and where we see signs of affliction. Notwithstanding the Latin American trend toward popular (and middle-class) protest against the economic policies of democratic regimes and the early exit of sitting presidents, we see considerable diversity today in how citizens perceive the effectiveness of their democratic governments to administer social and economic policy, and on the basis of those evaluations, we also see wide variation in their subjective support for democracy and levels of voter turnout. In the next section, I examine two hypotheses about why support for democracy may be eroding, globalization and neoliberalism, and the gap between government performance and citizen expectations in the three areas of highest salience to Latin American voters: economic security, personal security, and corruption. In the final section, I contend that the link between a healthy democracy and less than perfect government performance is the effective functioning of the institutions of political representation. I conclude with a series of unanswered questions that call for more research.

WHAT HAVE WE LEARNED ABOUT DEMOCRACY'S ADVANCE?

Several key theses have emerged in this volume to account for the dramatic change in Latin American politics of the past quarter century. In Chapter 1 of this volume, Scott Mainwaring and Aníbal Pérez-Liñán identify the key factors accounting for democratic survivability. Their research, echoed in the country chapters by various authors, including Kurt Weyland, Elisabeth Jean Wood, and Michael Coppedge, confirms empirically that international change was crucial in insulating new democracies from potential authoritarian reversals. There are at least three reasons for believing that international change was so important in advancing and safeguarding the Third Wave of democratization in Latin America. The first relates to the shift in U.S. foreign policy away from supporting friendly dictatorships toward insisting that its allies remain democracies, and the role of hemispheric institutions such as the Organization of American States and Mercosur in making plain that democracy was a continuing criterion for membership. Signals from the international community provided powerful disincentives to would-be coup plotters in Peru (1992), Guatemala (1993), and Paraguay (1996) (Valenzuela 1997). Both U.S. and international organizations pushed warring sides toward peace in those countries that had been wracked

by civil war. As Wood explains it in her chapter, in El Salvador, international actors such as the United Nations observer mission (ONUSAL) “met many of the costs of the peace and reinforced its benefits through ongoing, comparatively close scrutiny of compliance with the peace agreement.”

Second, along with changed international norms there has been a change in regional mentalities. The international environment was radically altered by the collapse of communism in Europe, as well as by cultural change in the Catholic Church, which of course had long been a pillar of the conservative order. In their chapter, Mainwaring and Pérez-Liñán also demonstrate that the collapse of the communist bloc and the experience in exile of so many members of Latin America’s left – an experience that tamed their passions for socialism and led them to appreciate the inherent value of democracy (cf. Hite 2000) – was certainly instrumental in securing the Third Wave. Continuing with the Salvadoran case, Wood asserts that involvement with international actors, initially as a result of U.S. insistence on liberalizing the political regime in the 1980s and later as a result of UN mediation in fostering the peace process, was essential to an increasing acceptance of liberal political norms, which led to the “unprecedented acceptance of electoral competition by actors on the right.” Steven Levitsky, in his chapter, makes a similar observation about Argentina, where, he claims, the 1976–83 dictatorship produced a “profound metamorphosis of Argentine political culture.” He contends that as a result of the horrors of dictatorship, issues of human rights and democracy gained unprecedented salience among the electorate in the 1980s, an elite consensus formed around the rules of the game, and in the 1990s the mass-level commitment to democracy also grew.

While democracy-enabling value change generally caught on across the region, it has not done so everywhere. In one of the most dramatic cases – Colombia – four guerrilla groups were reincorporated into civil society in the early 1990s, but the Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia (Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia; FARC) and the National Liberation Army (Ejército de Liberación Nacional; ELN) actually *deepened* their radical discourse, as Ana María Bejarano and Eduardo Pizarro are quick to note in Chapter 8. The stubborn radicalism of the left in turn radicalized the right, fueled the growth of paramilitary groups, and rocked the foundations of one of the longest standing democratic regimes in Latin America. The case of Brazil is less clear. In his chapter, Weyland downplays the importance for democratic stability of value change in Brazil: He characterizes the elite commitment to democracy as only “somewhat stronger” under the postauthoritarian regime than under the Second Wave democracy and value change at the mass level as “even weaker.” Yet, he concedes (p. 93) that Brazilian democracy has been “virtually secure” in Brazil since 1995 (ten years after the military left power) owing to “ideological convergence brought about by the fall of Communism.” If such convergence cannot be directly linked to attachments to democracy per se on the part of elite actors on the right, it has been facilitated by the spread of neoliberal economics in the Third Wave of democratization, a third international change that altered the trajectory of Latin American regimes.

Many scholars believe that the introduction of market-oriented reforms in Latin America has eroded democratic institutions and popular support for democracy. The reforms are believed to have had this effect because they cause unemployment to rise, more families to fall into poverty, and income disparities to widen – and also because they constrain the policy choices of governments, making impossible badly needed and anticipated social reform. The evidence for this position is not as persuasive as one might expect, however. Weyland and Wood have stressed the positive effects of these reforms for the survival of democratic regimes. For Weyland, the collapse of communism and the spread of neoliberalism have narrowed the ideological spectrum inside Brazil, put political and socioeconomic elites “at ease,” and stimulated greater acceptance of the uncertainty created by democracy. Wood makes a similar argument about El Salvador. After charting the economic diversification of the Salvadoran coffee elite in the 1980s, she recounts that the Cristiani faction of ARENA developed and proposed a set of neoliberal policy reforms, which were attractive to the elite for at least three important reasons: They could justify reprivatizing nationalized sectors; they would render the state incapable of threatening elite economic interests even if a party hostile to elite interests later governed; and the liberalization of capital flows specifically would discipline the state against redistributive measures. The same arguments could well be made across the Latin American continent. From Mexico to Argentina, the adoption of market reforms and the opening of Latin American economies to trade and capital flows has had the effect of attenuating the great postwar conflicts between capital and labor, restricting the capacity of governments to enact redistributive policies, and halting the politically expedient practice of passing along the costs of inflation.

International change, value change, and the diminished threat of communist subversion or even radical redistributive policies have in turn been reflected in perhaps the most dramatic difference between the past and the present to anyone who has studied Latin America over this quarter century and earlier – the retreat of the military. No longer do civilian elites seek out the military to settle scores with their opponents – not after the long, dark night of authoritarian rule. The prosecution and conviction of top military officers under the Alfonsín government in Argentina and the military dictator Gen. Luis García Meza (1980–81) and some of his colleagues in Bolivia (Mayorga, this volume) has served to raise the bar for future military intervention. Weyland attributes the diminished propensity of the Brazilian military to intervene in politics (as it had in 1955–56, 1961, and 1964) to the reorganization of the military during the military regime, and its greater unity. The admonitions of some about the great reserve of military power aside (see especially Stepan 1988, but also Hagopian 1990), since 1985 there have been no military uprisings, and no saber rattling in Brazil, even when a more radical Workers’ Party (PT) appeared it might win the presidential election in 1989 and the president was impeached in 1992 for gross corruption. Most impressively, both the administrations of Fernando Collor de Mello and Fernando Henrique Cardoso made great strides in subordinating the military to civilian direction (Hunter 2000: 116), most

prominently by establishing a unified defense ministry in 1999 and placing it under the direction of a civilian minister.⁴

But perhaps the most spectacular differences between civil–military relations in the Second and Third Waves of democracy are evident in Argentina and El Salvador, two countries in which the military had been deeply entrenched in politics since the Great Depression. In El Salvador, as Wood puts it, between 1932 (when the military perpetrated one of the most dramatic peasant massacres in the history of the twentieth century) and the civil war of the early 1980s, active duty or retired military officers “ruled the polity” in alliance with economic elites (through the National Conciliation Party or Partido de Conciliación Nacional; PCN), and this oligarchic alliance of hardline officers and landlords, moreover, was able repeatedly to thwart attempts at reform of land tenure and labor relations by other military factions (as it did in 1944, 1960, 1972, and 1976). Against this backdrop, the accomplishments of the peace process, including the introduction of constitutional reforms to the mission and prerogatives of the military, the dissolution of the National Guard and the Treasury Police and the founding of a new civilian police force, and the purging of more than a hundred officers from the ranks of the military for human rights abuses, are nothing short of remarkable.

In Argentina, the great change began with the prosecution of top military officers by the Alfonsín government for human rights abuses in the 1976–83 period. Although the scope of these trials was later circumscribed as a result of the *carapintada* rebellion of April 1987 (with the “due obedience” clause), and convicted officers later (controversially) pardoned by the Menem government, the principle of civilian control over the military in Argentina was unquestionably established – to a greater extent than at any time since 1930 – and the military’s presence in politics reduced to insignificance. Since that time, the military has had no role in the cabinet, military officers have not issued proclamations, and there has been no military show of force in the streets. The 1988 Defense Law denied the military command any policy-making role and prohibited the armed forces from intervening in matters of internal security. Key areas of military decision making, including the budget, procurement, and national defense strategy, were placed under the civilian-led defense ministry. The Menem government slashed the military budget by a third, abolished the draft, and privatized military-owned enterprises. The bottom line has been

⁴ One prominent Brazilian scholar, Jorge Zaverucha, would give a decidedly more pessimistic view of the containment of military influence in contemporary Brazilian democracy. For Zaverucha (2000), Brazilian democracy is fragile, and the military is only partially under civilian control. The armed forces are not as powerful as they were under the authoritarian regime, but they are nonetheless still the “fourth branch of government.” More specifically, he claims (2000: 10) that thirteen years after the assumption of the presidency by a civilian, the military continue to maintain many authoritarian enclaves, or, reserved domains of power in the state apparatus. Perhaps most provocatively, he claims (2000: 12) that the power of the Brazilian military was less subtle, but no less powerful, than it was in Chile. His reservations aside, I stand by my overall interpretation.

summarized by Levitsky in his chapter: By the late 1990s, “military spending was under the exclusive control of the economic ministry, responsibility for determining the missions and deployment of the armed forces was in the hands of the foreign ministry, and the ‘bulk of serious military effort’ was being devoted to external peacekeeping missions.” Most telling, perhaps, is what appears to be the permanent fracture of the half-century military–elite alliance. Citing Gibson (1996), Levitsky underscores that conservatives who had previously turned to the military for protection invested instead in electoral politics. From Buenos Aires to Guatemala, the fracture of the civilian–military elite is why, in the words of Carlos Acuña, “the future is no longer what it used to be” (Acuña 1994).

There is also a greater resolve to make political institutions work. During their transitions from authoritarian rule, several countries, including Chile and Brazil, entertained proposals to shift from presidential to parliamentary democracies. These proposals were ultimately not accepted, but the elite and public debates about their merits did shine attention on the need either to reform other institutions or to develop informal ones to overcome the most pernicious effects of divided government. Several countries discussed in this volume *did* institute significant reforms. New electoral institutions were created in Mexico and Bolivia, electoral reforms in Chile and Bolivia attenuated polarization in the party system, and the executive was strengthened in relation to the legislature in Brazil – a development that facilitated the legislative process.

These reforms were each, in their own way, hugely consequential. In her chapter, Beatriz Magaloni explains with elegant precision the calculations in the Mexican case that led to the creation of institutions for a democratic transition, especially the Federal Electoral Institute (IFE). She explains why, given voter preferences, the PRI had little choice but to cede authority to the IFE, and as she contends, this decision paved the way for the erosion of the one-party dominant authoritarian regime. In Chile, the binomial electoral system instituted in 1989 (by the outgoing Pinochet regime) has had the effect of attenuating polarization in the political system. Because deputies are elected in two-member districts from lists within which votes are pooled, and only candidates from the top two lists can win representation in any district, the overwhelming incentive has been for parties to band together in coalitions. The electoral law, as much as any structural or ideological factor, is believed by most observers of Chilean politics to be responsible for the redefinition of the Chilean party system from one of polarized to moderate pluralism. In the Brazilian case, although some observers view the executive decree authority to issue “provisional measures” enshrined in the 1988 Constitution as pernicious because the president can use them to circumvent Congress, Weyland emphasizes the governability-enhancing effects of this institution, and its contribution to the substantive performance of the new democracy. In particular, the prerogative to issue even temporary decrees can help the executive to set the agenda for parliamentary deliberation because Congress must afford the provisional measures priority attention.

The Bolivian reforms are particularly illustrative. In his chapter, René Mayorga credits the emergence of a moderate multiparty system with three

major parties – the MNR (Movimiento Nacionalista Revolucionario or National Revolutionary Movement), ADN (Acción Democrática Nacionalista or Nationalist Democratic Action), and MIR (Movimiento Izquierda Revolucionario or Movement of the Revolutionary Left) – to the creation of an autonomous National Election Commission in 1991 and the adoption in 1994 of a mixed-member proportional electoral system modeled on the German system. The new system reserves seats for 68 deputies (of 130) chosen by first-past-the-post voting in single-member districts and 62 for deputies selected by party-list voting according to proportional representation in nine multimember regional districts. (The overall allocation of seats is determined by the list vote obtained by each party, with seats determined by the d'Hondt formula for parties whose vote total meets a 3 percent threshold.) Added to these and other institutional changes were behavioral changes that produced in the 1980s a system of what Mayorga calls “parliamentarized presidentialism.” Article 90 of the Constitution (in force since 1851 but applied only three times in Bolivian history prior to the current democratic period – once in the nineteenth century and twice in the 1940s) required that presidents be chosen by Congress when there is no popular vote majority but made no explicit provision for the process by which that coalition would be generated and did not specify that the top vote-getter should be selected. In the 1980s, in the context of a terrible economic crisis, Bolivia's parties learned to select the president by bargaining votes in Congress and building postelectoral parliamentary governing coalitions. The practice of forming a postelection coalition to select the president, which forms the basis of a majority government, has persisted and provided a strong base of support for presidential initiatives in the Congress. Mayorga credits the process of bargaining that generated consensus and strong coalition governments with enabling Bolivia's presidential democracy in the 1990s to escape the sort of exercise of presidential power elsewhere in Latin America during times of economic reform that eroded democratic institutions.

In some cases where new democratic institutions were created or existing democratic institutions were fruitfully redesigned, democracies outperformed their pasts. Adjustments to and investments in political institutions have enabled the “right” legislation – economic reforms and policies, and even moderate environmental protection policies and educational reforms but not radical, redistributive reforms – to get passed. In the Third Wave, institutional development was not uniformly positive, however, and where institutions atrophied, as was the case with Venezuelan and Peruvian political parties, or were revised in ways that unwittingly undermined their effectiveness, as was true with Colombia's party reform of 1991 that resulted in an enormous disorganization among parties and an extreme atomization of political representation (Bejarano and Pizarro, this volume), democracies became destabilized. If representative parties and presidents with Congressional support are essential to democratic stability, deinstitutionalization can put democracy in grave peril.

In these countries where institutions faltered, the Third Wave of democratization started to recede beginning in 1992, the year of two coup attempts in Venezuela and the Peruvian *autogolpe*. In Peru, we know, this interruption

of democracy was temporary. Elsewhere, the loss of faith has mercifully not resulted in a breakdown of democracy, but it has set it back. Our task is to understand when fragile democracies will limp along and when they can become vulnerable to creeping authoritarian incursions, if not coups. It is to this question that I next turn my attention.

WHERE IS DEMOCRACY FLOURISHING, AND WHERE IS IT IN TROUBLE? PERFORMANCE AND PERCEPTIONS

Impressionistically, most observers today would doubtless say that Latin America's most successful democracies are Costa Rica, Uruguay, and Chile. Costa Rica has remained a model democracy for more than five decades, and military regimes in Uruguay and Chile, however brutal, are now seen as blips on the longer trajectory of stable, democratic governance. Although this volume did not examine the cases of Costa Rica, Uruguay, and Chile because we did not view successful democratic governance in these cases as particularly surprising, reinserting these cases into our analysis would now enable us to identify the key factors sustaining and nourishing democracy in Latin America today.

In order to advance our understanding of the diversity of Latin America's experiences with democracy, a more systematic assessment of democratic performance and its role in explaining how much and why citizens support their democracies is warranted. The first obligation of democratic regimes is to guarantee political rights and civil liberties. Of the twelve countries included in this sample, three – Chile, Costa Rica, and Uruguay – were scored by Freedom House as free in each of the eleven years from 1992 through 2003 (Table 11.1). El Salvador has been free since 1997; Mexico, since its transition to democracy in 2000; and Peru, since 2001 (and Alberto Fujimori's exit from the presidency). Brazil has also moved toward becoming a freer country since 2003, without a change of regime. Argentina experienced two years of partial freedom during the country's 2001–02 crisis, but in 2003 it moved back into the “free” column. Scored free for every year except 1995, Bolivia was downgraded to “partly free” in 2003. Most disturbingly, Colombia and Guatemala have been only partly free in each of the eleven years covered. Colombia has especially experienced a sustained deterioration of civil liberties.

A broader evaluation of democratic performance would take into account the extent to which democratic regimes are responsive and accountable to their citizens, which is notoriously hard to measure, as well as how effectively, transparently, and cleanly they govern. Table 11.2 summarizes estimates of six dimensions of governance developed by the World Bank's Global Governance project that attempt to capture many of the indicators in which we are interested: voice and accountability, political stability, government effectiveness, regulatory quality, rule of law, and control of corruption (Kaufmann, Kraay, and Mastruzzi 2003). The first two – voice and accountability and political stability – generally capture the strength of democracy; the second two – democratic governance and regulatory quality – its effectiveness; and the last

TABLE 11.1. *Freedom House Ratings of Political Rights and Civil Liberties: Twelve Latin American Countries, 1993–2003*

Country	1993	1994	1995	1996	1997	1998	1999	2000	2001	2002	2003
Argentina	5	5	5	5	5	6	5	3	6	6	4
Bolivia	5	5	6	5	4	4	4	4	4	5	6
Brazil	7	6	6	6	7	7	7	6	6	5	5
Chile	4	4	4	4	4	5	4	4	4	3	2
Colombia	6	7	8	8	8	7	8	8	8	8	8
Costa Rica	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
El Salvador	6	6	6	6	5	5	5	5	5	5	5
Guatemala	9	9	9	7	7	7	7	7	7	8	8
Mexico	8	8	8	7	7	7	7	5	5	4	4
Peru	9	9	9	7	9	9	9	6	4	5	5
Uruguay	4	4	4	3	3	3	3	2	2	2	2
Venezuela	6	6	6	5	5	5	8	8	8	7	7

Notes: Scores provided represent combined ratings for political rights and civil liberties. Both are measured on a one-to-seven scale, with one representing the highest degree of freedom and seven the lowest. Until 2003, countries whose combined average ratings for political rights and for civil liberties fell between 1 and 2.5 were designated “free”; between 3.0 and 5.0, “partly free”; and between 5.5 and 7.0, “not free.” Beginning with the ratings for 2003, countries whose combined average ratings fall between 3.0 and 5.0 are “partly free,” and those between 5.5 and 7.0 are “not free.” Countries receiving the “partly free” label were: Argentina: 2001–02; Bolivia: 1995, 2003; Brazil: 1993–2001; Colombia, 1993–2003; El Salvador, 1993–96; Guatemala: 1993–2003; Mexico: 1993–99; Peru: 1993–2000; and Venezuela: 1993–95, 1999–2003.

Source: Data are from annual editions of Freedom House, *Freedom in the World*, available as an Excel spreadsheet, “Annual Freedom in the World Country Scores, 1972 through 2003,” at <http://www.freedomhouse.org/ratings/index.htm> (retrieved on March 11, 2004).

TABLE 11.2. *Democratic Governance in Twelve Latin American Countries, 2002*

Country	Voice and Accountability		Political Stability		Government Effectiveness		Regulatory Quality		Rule of Law		Control of Corruption		Point Estimate Sum
	Point Estimate	Percentile Rank	Point Estimate	Percentile Rank	Point Estimate	Percentile Rank	Point Estimate	Percentile Rank	Point Estimate	Percentile Rank	Point Estimate	Percentile Rank	
Chile	+1.12	84.3	+1.04	85.9	+1.19	86.6	+1.50	90.2	+1.30	87.1	+1.55	90.7	+7.7
Costa Rica	+1.16	84.8	+1.06	86.5	+0.37	66.6	+0.74	72.7	+0.67	72.2	+0.88	79.4	+4.88
Uruguay	+0.95	77.8	+0.91	79.5	+0.51	68.6	+0.48	67.0	+0.56	69.1	+0.79	75.8	+4.2
Mexico	+0.33	59.6	+0.22	50.8	+0.15	61.9	+0.49	68.0	-0.22	52.1	-0.19	52.1	+0.78
Brazil	+0.28	58.1	+0.17	48.1	-0.22	50.0	+0.26	63.4	-0.30	50.0	-0.05	56.7	+0.14
El Salvador	+0.06	51.5	+0.35	56.8	-0.53	35.6	+0.04	56.2	-0.46	39.7	-0.54	36.6	-1.08
Peru	+0.22	57.6	-0.67	25.4	-0.47	38.7	+0.24	62.9	-0.44	40.7	-0.20	51.5	-1.32
Bolivia	+0.01	50.0	-0.20	36.8	-0.53	34.5	-0.11	50.5	-0.60	32.5	-0.82	25.3	-2.25
Guatemala	-0.48	35.4	-0.43	32.4	-0.61	32.0	-0.09	52.1	-0.84	21.6	-0.71	30.9	-3.16
Argentina	+0.12	52.5	-0.74	23.8	-0.49	37.6	-0.84	19.6	-0.73	27.8	-0.77	27.8	-3.45
Colombia	-0.55	30.8	-1.78	4.9	-0.39	45.4	-0.04	53.1	-0.75	26.8	-0.47	38.7	-3.98
Venezuela	-0.41	38.9	-1.20	17.3	-1.14	10.3	-0.54	34.5	-1.04	13.4	-0.94	18.6	-5.27
Standard Error	.17-.18		.19-.25		.15-.18		.17-.19		.13-.16		.14-.18		

Notes: Indicators are based on several hundred individual variables measuring perceptions of governance, drawn from twenty-five separate data sources constructed by eighteen different organizations. Authors assign these individual measures of governance to categories capturing key dimensions of governance and use an unobserved components model to construct six aggregate governance indicators in each of the four periods. The authors also present the point estimates of the dimensions of governance as well as the margins of error for each country. Margins of error are calculated separately for each indicator in each country. For the countries in our sample, they range from .17 to .18 for voice and accountability, .19 to .25 for political stability, .15 to .18 for government effectiveness, .17 to .19 for regulatory quality, .13 to .16 for rule of law, and .14 to .18 for control of corruption. In each of these cases, the highest standard error is recorded for El Salvador.

Source: Kaufmann, Kraay, and Mastruzzi (2003).

two – rule of law and control of corruption – the transparency and fairness of democratic regimes. Country rankings are provided along with the point estimates. The estimates are based on a weighted average of the sources for each country (which combined several hundred variables drawn from twenty-five separate data sources constructed by eighteen different organizations, including Freedom House, *The Economist* Intelligence Unit, Gallup International, Latinobarómetro, and Standard and Poor's DRI McGraw-Hill) and have an expected value across countries of zero and a standard deviation of one; thus the scores lie between -2.5 and 2.5 .⁵ I have simply summarized the point estimates to provide a scale of the quality of democratic governance in the countries in our sample.

The countries that we typically classify as strong, high-quality democracies – Chile, Costa Rica, and Uruguay – also score the highest on the World Bank's six indicators of governance. They clearly receive the highest percentile ranking on voice and accountability, political stability, government effectiveness, rule of law, and control of corruption, and, along with Mexico, on regulatory quality. Mexico and Brazil are middling democratic performers. Both are perceived as providing a reasonable degree of voice and accountability, and both are comparatively effective states, at least as measured by their regulatory quality. Mexico's government is rated as significantly more effective than Brazil's, though Brazil is perceived as having achieved a greater degree of control of corruption. The performance of these regimes varies considerably, but both are considered to be positive.

The next set of countries shows promise and flaws. At the top of this group is El Salvador, which overall scores better perhaps than the impression left us by Wood's sober account of the flaws of Salvadoran democracy; its weakest areas are government effectiveness, rule of law, and control of corruption. Though both are considered less than politically stable, Peru is perceived to have a higher-quality democracy than Bolivia. Such a conclusion may have seemed surprising just a few years ago given that democracy in Peru appeared to be imperiled under Fujimori and in Bolivia, more stable than any other in the Andean region. Yet, in retrospect, Bolivia's democratic regime was precariously perched on a foundation of perceived corruption, weak rule of law, and a relatively weak (by Latin American standards) degree of voice and accountability, which may have led to the ouster of President Gonzalo Sánchez de Lozada. Peru, by contrast, has improved the control of corruption⁶ (at this point the difference between the two countries is vast), regulatory quality, and even the rule of law.

⁵ These measures are not perfect. Some components of "voice and accountability" actually measure freedom and rights (including survey responses to the question of the extent to which the state and/or its allied groups engage in repression of its citizens as well as Freedom House's measures of civil liberties, political rights, and press freedom) and stability (including responses to questions such as "how likely is the government to remain in power") (Kaufmann, Kraay, and Mastruzzi 2003: 91). Needless to say, a government may protect freedom and be stable, but not give voice to citizens and be accountable to them.

⁶ One reason may be because of the highly regarded performance of the office of the ombudsman.

Argentina, which in previous years had unambiguously been perceived as the next strongest, most effective, and transparent democracy in the region after Chile, Costa Rica, and Uruguay, has now fallen to one of the worst democratic performers in the region, especially because of political instability, poor regulatory quality, and the relative absence of the rule of law.⁷ Finally, Guatemala, Colombia, and Venezuela score toward the bottom of Latin America's democracies on most measures. The problematic nature of Guatemala's democracy underscored by Mitchell Seligson in his chapter is most evident in low scores on voice and accountability and the rule of law. The years of political violence in Colombia and the erosion of democracy in Venezuela during the Chávez administration have dropped two of the region's oldest democracies to the bottom of the list. While its democratic governments have long been perceived as reasonably effective and capable of regulation, Colombia is especially penalized for political instability. Venezuela's scores are particularly abysmal along the dimensions of political stability, government effectiveness, rule of law, and corruption.

How significant is the performance of democratic regimes in explaining citizen support? One recent scholarly thesis holds that countries in the Third Wave of democratization that have introduced competitive elections before establishing the basic institutions of the modern state, including the rule of law – these “incomplete” democracies – run the risk of falling into a “low-level equilibrium trap in which the inadequacies of elites are matched by low popular demands and expectations” (Rose and Shin 2001: 331).⁸ We might logically ask whether this has happened in Latin America, and if there is a correlation between the quality of democratic governance and the support for democracy. The most commonly used comparative referent for the extent of citizen support for democracy is the level of agreement with the statement, “Democracy is preferable to any other form of government.” By this measure, public support for democracy in Latin America is highest in Uruguay, Costa Rica, Argentina, and Venezuela, where 78, 77, 68, and 67 percent of respondents, respectively, agreed with this statement in 2003 (Table 1.11). Mass support for democracy lies in a medium range in Mexico (53 percent), Peru (52 percent), Chile (50 percent), and Bolivia (50 percent). At the other end of the spectrum, only 46 percent of Colombians, 45 percent of Salvadorans, 35 percent of Brazilians, and 33 percent of Guatemalans could agree that democracy was their preferred form of government. In 2002, citizens of each of these four countries were the most open to a nondemocratic government, if it could solve the country's economic problems (62 percent of Brazilians, 64 percent of Guatemalans, 57 percent of Colombians, and 55 percent of Salvadorans were open to such a possibility). Yet, one of the highest levels of support for democracy was

⁷ In 2000–01, Argentina received scores of .57 for voice and accountability, .55 for political stability, .18 for government effectiveness, .25 for regulatory quality, .22 for rule of law, and –.36 for control of corruption (Kaufmann, Kraay, and Zoido-Lobaton 2002).

⁸ Many scholars will find this argument similar to Zakaria's well-known thesis of “illiberal democracy” (Zakaria 1997).

found in Venezuela – 67 percent of Venezuelans supported democracy (only in Uruguay, Costa Rica, and Argentina was support for democracy higher) – but Venezuela’s ranking on governance indicators was across the board the lowest in Latin America. On the whole, the correlation between this measure of support for democracy and the quality of democratic governance is not statistically significant.

There are other reasons why faith in these responses would be misplaced. Public support for democracy is notoriously highly volatile.⁹ Presumably, public support for democracy does not evaporate from one month to the next, though that is precisely how this loss of support often manifests itself. Of the countries under examination here, the greatest percentage point declines in public support for democracy in the years from 1996 to 2003 were registered in El Salvador (11), Peru (11), Bolivia (14), Colombia (14), and Guatemala (18). Rates of decline were even higher in Paraguay and Panama (19 and 24 percentage points, respectively). In Mexico, public support for democracy dropped in a single year from 63 (2002) to 53 percent (2003). (See again Table 1.11.) Moreover, it is often difficult to make sense of public responses to this question on its own. In a recent Eurobarometer survey of twenty-one postcommunist countries, the correlation between each country’s Freedom House score and aggregate satisfaction with democracy found in surveys was .001, and more Albanians (76 percent) were satisfied with their democracy than Britons (46 percent) (Rose and Shin 2001: 339–41). Apparently, the comparative measure on which we most rely for citizen attitudes toward democracy is volatile and barely correlated to “real” levels of democracy.

From what measures of public attitudes or behavior – if not support for democracy – can we then infer something meaningful about the health of democracy? Inevitably, when working with a small set of countries, answers to any one survey item in a single year may reflect national idiosyncrasies and provide an inadequate foundation upon which to draw broader comparative conclusions. To compensate for the weakness of these measures, I created an index of citizen satisfaction with democracy for the twelve Latin American countries in our sample comprised of an average of six indicators: levels of support for democracy (2000–04 average), satisfaction with democracy (2000–04 average), and trust in government (2003); numbers responding that democracy is the best governmental system (2003–04 average) and that voting can make a difference (2004); and valid votes as a percentage of the voting age population (1990–2002 average) (Table 11.3). The first five are captured from responses to the surveys of public opinion, and the sixth, an average of turnout in democratic elections, matches opinion with the most fundamental act of citizenship in a democracy.

⁹ Cynthia McClintock (1999b: 342) has appropriately pointed out that from 1982 to 1994 Peruvians consistently supported democracy even when real alternatives – a military dictatorship (which earlier had distributed land, nationalized oil, and brought workers into management of state enterprises) and revolution (in the guise of the Maoist Shining Path) – were available. Yet in 1992, 88 percent of Limeños also backed Alberto Fujimori’s *autogolpe*.

TABLE 11.3. *Citizen Perceptions of Democracy in Latin America, 2000–2004*

Country	Support for Democracy ^a	Satisfaction with Democracy ^b	Importance of Voting ^c	Valid Votes/VAP ^d	Trust in Government ^e	Democracy is the Best System ^f	Index
Uruguay	79	53	71	92	19	84	66
Costa Rica	75	56	51	67	23	80	59
Argentina	65	28	65	71	45	80	59
Chile	52	32	53	67	46	71	53
Panama	53	34	72	68	20	71	53
Venezuela	67	43	68	36	28	74	53
Honduras	56	41	49	64	25	72	51
Brazil	36	23	59	54	42	69	47
Nicaragua	52	30	50	74	12	66	47
Mexico	52	23	52	57	24	75	47
El Salvador	45	31	61	37	21	61	42
Colombia	43	20	57	30	33	64	41
Peru	56	15	54	49	14	59	41
Bolivia	53	21	37	52	14	62	40
Ecuador	47	19	45	53	10	55	38
Paraguay	41	10	50	52	16	55	38
Guatemala	38	26	54	32	7	46	34
Latin America	54	30	60	56	24	68	49

^a Percent agreeing with statement, “Democracy is preferable to any other kind of government,” 2000–04 average.

^b Percent responding they are “very satisfied” and “fairly satisfied” with the functioning of democracy, 2000–04 average.

^c Percent responding “How one votes can make things different in the future,” 2004.

^d Valid votes as percent of voting age population, 1990–2002 average.

^e Percent expressing “a lot of confidence” and “some confidence” in government, 2003.

^f Percent agreeing with the statement, “Democracy may have problems, but it is the best system of government,” 2003–04 average.

Sources: Latinobarómetro 2003, 2004; UNDP 2004: 87.

While not perfect, this index solves for some anomalies. If we look only at the response to the single question of support for democracy, Brazil appears to be one of the two weakest democracies in Latin America. But by taking into account trust in government, satisfaction with democracy, the opinion that democracy is better than the alternatives, and the rate at which Brazilians actually turn out to vote, Brazil's democracy appears stronger, and the contrast with Guatemala, the other country at the bottom of the support for democracy column, is now stark. When these indicators are factored in, Guatemala falls to the bottom of the index, a view that conforms to Seligson's interpretation of the state of Guatemalan democracy, and in Brazil, Mexico, and El Salvador, all things considered, democracy may be as strong as it has ever been. The best supported democracies are Uruguay, Costa Rica, and Argentina.

What explains these broader public perceptions about democracy and the importance citizens attach to voting participation? Although many scholars and pollsters believe that support for democracy may be correlated with the performance of the government of the day and especially the popularity of the president, in fact, the lowest presidential approval ratings in Latin America in 2003 were in Uruguay and Costa Rica (the countries with the highest support for democracy). The quality of democratic governance more broadly gives us greater leverage over our question. The correlation between the index of satisfaction with democracy and the quality of democratic governance (Table 11.2) is .57 (significant at the .05 level). When this relationship is mapped (Figure 11.1), we see that most countries can be fitted in a predictable pattern:

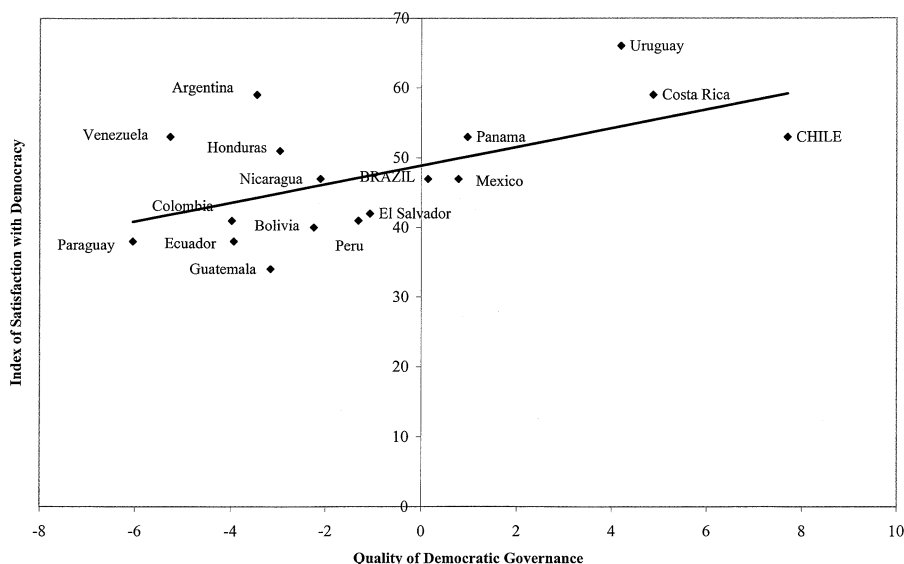


FIGURE 11.1. Democracy in Latin America: Performance and Perceptions.
Sources: Tables 11.2 and 11.3.

Support for and satisfaction with democracy and trust in its institutions tends to rise along with the quality of democratic governance. There are, however, outliers. In Venezuela, Argentina, and even Uruguay, satisfaction with democracy clearly outperforms the quality of democratic governance; in Chile and in Guatemala, it falls far short. Clearly, we still need to discover the variables that attenuate the impact of regime performance and that explain democracy's advances and setbacks.

EXPLAINING DEMOCRACY'S SETBACKS

The great trends that explain the surprising wave of democratization in the region do not explain democracy's setbacks where an elite consensus in favor of democracy was strong and political institutions appeared to be functioning well. The collapse of communism and the transformation of the left cannot in and of themselves guarantee quality democratic governance. International support for democracy cannot inspire citizen loyalty, participation, and confidence in democratic government. And political institutions reformed to overcome deadlock, polarization, and fragmentation might smooth out the governing process, but it cannot ensure that citizens will endorse all policy courses set by their governments. These factors alone cannot enhance the quality of democracy in contexts where it can be perilously low, especially when economic and social inclusion so palpably lags behind.

These shortcomings suggest that we need to move beyond the study of regime transition and political institutions that has dominated much political science scholarship of the past decade and a half. These frameworks served us well when we were attempting to explain exits from authoritarian rule and the capacity of democratic political systems to build an elite consensus for democracy. But in this era of mass democracy in which democratic regimes benefit from an international protection racket, if we are to explain the solidity or fragility of democratic regimes we will need to treat democratic governance not merely as the ability of the executive to get a reform agenda or a budget proposal through Congress, but also as the responsiveness of governments to constituent demands. We will need to assess how well the outputs of public policy – well-paying jobs, safe streets, and access to quality schools and health care, delivered by governments that are perceived to be clean and fair – meet the expectations of constituents. We will also need to reconnect the legislative process to citizen participation, government responsiveness, democratic accountability, and the quality of political representation. We need, in other words, to build a new approach to studying democratic regimes.

Beyond Transitions and Institutions: What Role for Citizens?

If citizen support makes democratic regimes in the Third Wave solid and the loss of that support makes them vulnerable to erosion, then we need to understand citizen expectations of government, perceptions of the policy course

that governments set, and evaluations of the success of those policies. The conventional wisdom maintains that high expectations followed transitions from authoritarian rule, and the results of market-oriented reforms have generated potentially destabilizing disappointment. Such a view recalls the paradigmatic argument advanced three decades ago by Michel Crozier, Samuel Huntington, and Joji Watanuki (1975), who in a justifiably influential work admonished that the democracies in Western Europe, North America, and Japan – the Trilateral region – were being “overloaded” with the demands of an array of citizens’ groups. States that caved were stretched beyond their capacities, ran deficits that fueled inflation, and, in turn, generated more discontent and a sense that governments could not govern. The notion that there was a tradeoff between democratic participation and democratic governance, advanced by Huntington (1968) years earlier, was challenged a quarter century later when Robert Putnam, Susan Pharr, and Russell Dalton (2000), asking whatever happened to the overload problem in advanced industrial democracies, found that where there had once been intense citizen mobilization and strong engagement with political institutions, there were now unmistakable signs of malaise and political disaffection: declining attachments to political parties, low rates of approval of parliaments, negative assessments of the “political class,” and declining levels of trust in government and elected officials. Such an interpretation built on the Putnamesque (and Tocquevillian) notion that government works best, and democracy is at its healthiest when government is engaged and held to account by its own civil society (Putnam 1993).

The question of how much participation on the part of civil society is ideal in a mass democracy and how it should best be channeled is at least as significant in Latin America today, where at stake is not just this year’s budget deficit or the functioning of regional governments but democracy itself, as in advanced industrial society then and now. On the one hand, inflated expectations on the part of mobilized voters are alleged to have fueled neopopulist politics that undermine fiscal discipline, democratic institutions, and the rule of law. On the other hand, the experience of the Latin American cases in the Third Wave of democracy examined in this volume may reveal a more dangerous side effect of the democratic dilemma than heretofore appreciated: What “works” when government is performing well – that is, a low level of popular mobilization and a low level of demands – may leave democracy vulnerable when government performance falters. Loss of confidence in government and political institutions, once eroded, may not be easily recouped.

While there are many possible explanations for the magnitude and the causes of citizen support for and disaffection with their democratic regimes, two stand out for the frequency and vehemence with which they have been asserted, and for the logically intuitive nature of their arguments. The first concerns the impact of globalization and the adoption of neoliberal economic policies. If neoliberalism is claimed to have contributed to the longevity of the Third Wave of democratization by calming nervous *elites*, it is also alleged to have jeopardized it by eroding *popular* support for democracy in Latin America today.

The second concerns the gap between government performance and citizen expectations. I do not pretend to test these hypotheses adequately, but I examine each in light of what we do know, and I raise questions for further research.

Globalization and Neoliberalism

Writing of the Trilateral countries, Alesina and Wacziarg (2000) conjectured that the secular decline in public support for democratic governments in advanced industrial society could be caused by globalization. The increased openness of countries to global trade and the rapid mobility of international capital is alleged to have constrained OECD (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development) governments from adopting policies that conform to the position of the median voter, which in turn has increased public dissatisfaction with government. The idea is theoretically appealing but probably exaggerated in the case of the advanced industrial societies, where such externally imposed constraints are not hard (Garrett 1998; Mosley 2003). However, recent research has shown that governments in developing countries are subject to more constraints than their OECD counterparts (Kaufman and Segura-Ubiergo 2001; Mosley 2003). Kaufman and Segura-Ubiergo (2001: 554) find that trade integration has had a consistently negative effect on aggregate social spending, and this is compounded by openness to capital markets. The negative effect of international economic integration operates primarily in the area of social security transfers (mainly pensions), while health and education expenditures are far less vulnerable. In Latin America, the conversion to neoliberalism is alleged to have enhanced these constraints. Latin American countries are now as open to trade as at any time since the Great Depression, and financial mobility has so reduced the scope of financial policy that Ecuador and El Salvador have joined Panama in dollarizing their economies, and Argentina and Brazil both adopted currency reforms that pegged the peso and the real to the dollar (with the Argentine policy a far stricter variant), until these exchange rates became unsustainable. Brazil let the real float in early 1999 (resulting in a huge devaluation), and Argentina abandoned its currency board and convertibility plan after its banking system collapsed in December 2001.

Have the constraints of globalization dampened levels of public support for democratic regimes and governments? Do mass publics that reject globalization and neoliberal market reforms, and that identify democratic governments as responsible for ushering in those reforms, penalize those governments, as this thesis expects? In fact, on the one hand, Latin Americans are generally supportive of increased openness to international trade and foreign investment. In a Market and Opinion Research International (MORI) poll conducted in 1998, 85 percent of respondents in fourteen Latin American countries supported free trade, and 60 percent reported that foreign direct investment was good because it promotes economic growth (cited in Magaloni and Romero

2004: 11).¹⁰ On the other hand, on average, citizens are skeptical of state retrenchment. Support for private ownership in seven key sectors (oil, electricity, airlines, mines, telephone, water, and TV) in 1998 was lukewarm at best, and citizens in all fourteen Latin American countries included in the MORI survey expressed a preference for greater, not lesser, state involvement in the provision of education, health care, and pensions. Since then, support for privatization of state companies has eroded in every country in the region. In Latinobarómetro polls taken in 2003, support for privatization had fallen since 1998 by 24 percentage points, to its current low level of 22 percent (Table 11.4). Polls show that Latin Americans *generally* support a market economy, on average, 57 percent of Latin Americans agree with the statement “Only with a market economy can (country) become a developed country,” but only 16 percent were very or fairly satisfied with how the market economy worked in their country. Nearly three quarters were less satisfied with the delivery of privatized public services than they were before (Table 11.4). Magaloni and Romero (2004: 27) confirm that economic performance can dramatically shape citizen evaluations of neoliberal policies. Where the economy grew in the 1990s relative to the 1980s, respondents supported globalization. Where short-term inflation was high in the late 1990s relative to the 1980s, survey respondents embraced state retrenchment, but when macroeconomic stabilization had been achieved, they preferred state expansion.

Does increasing skepticism about state retrenchment from key industries and especially social services, then, translate into a loss of support for democracy? Do citizens who object to neoliberal *policies* penalize either their government or their democracy? For better or for worse, mass publics do not ascribe blame for their country’s economic problems to the impersonal forces of globalization, but rather they put the blame squarely on the doorstep of their governments. When asked in 2003 which of a list of institutions and actors were responsible for the economic problems, 63 percent of Latin Americans cited the “government’s economic policy,” but only 14 percent held the International Monetary Fund (IMF) responsible; 14 percent, “globalization”; 12 percent, “the banks”; and 8 percent, the World Trade Organization (WTO) (Latinobarómetro 2003: 17). The key question, of course, is whether voters assess a penalty merely in response to survey questions, or whether they impose an *electoral* penalty as well? If dissatisfaction is expressed politically at the ballot box, does it take the form of support for a democratic opponent, or an antisystem alternative?

Globalization, Neoliberalism, and Democracy

To begin, is satisfaction with market reform correlated with support for democracy? The short answer, in aggregate terms, is no. The correlation

¹⁰ The countries included ten of the twelve countries examined in this chapter: Argentina, Bolivia, Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Costa Rica, Guatemala, Mexico, Peru, and Venezuela. Also included were Dominican Republic, Ecuador, Panama, and Paraguay. El Salvador and Uruguay were omitted.

TABLE 11.4. *Popular Perceptions of Market-Oriented Reforms: Latin America, 2003*

	Privatization of State Companies ^a			Market Economy		Satisfaction with Privatization of Public Services		State Problem-Solving Capacity ^b	
	1998	2003	Change	Support ^c	Satisfaction ^d	Decrease ^e	Increase	Only a Few	Not Any
Argentina	32	12	-20	51	15	69	25	37	3
Bolivia	49	19	-30	54	11	75	21	47	19
Brazil	51	33	-18	69	25	69	26	43	7
Chile	51	29	-22	52	23	67	22	42	7
Colombia	39	24	-15	56	16	67	21	43	15
Costa Rica	-	-	-	64	17	-	-	60	15
El Salvador	54	15	-39	56	23	81	11	50	13
Guatemala	62	16	-46	33	15	69	15	27	26
Mexico	49	31	-18	65	17	60	35	53	11
Peru	44	22	-22	61	7	67	28	50	17
Uruguay	29	16	-13	59	11	-	-	19	5
Venezuela	51	32	-19	50	18	64	33	30	10
Latin America	46	22	-24	57	16	71	22	43	13

^a Q. Do you strongly agree, somewhat agree, somewhat disagree, or strongly disagree with each of the following phrases that I am going to read: "The privation of state companies has been beneficial to the country." Percent responding "strongly agree" and "somewhat agree."

^b Q. It is said that the state can solve our society's problems because it has the resources to do so. Would you say that the state can solve: All the problems/The majority of the problems/Quite a lot of problems/Only a few problems/The state cannot solve any problems.

^c Q. Do you strongly agree, somewhat agree, disagree, or strongly disagree with the following statement? Only with a market economy can (country) become a developed country. Percent responding "strongly agree" and "agree."

^d Q. In general, would you say that you are very satisfied, fairly satisfied, not very satisfied or not at all satisfied with the way market economy works in (country)? Percent responding "very satisfied" and "fairly satisfied."

^e Q. Public services like water, and electricity have been privatized. Considering price and quality, are you much more satisfied, more satisfied, less satisfied, or much less satisfied than you were before with these privatized services? Percent responding "less satisfied" and "much less satisfied."

Source: Latinobarómetro (2003: 14, 57, 58, 59, 16, 17).

between satisfaction with the market and both the simple measure of support for democracy and the composite index of citizen support for democracy is negative and insignificant.

Argentina's drama is illustrative. Although the Convertibility Plan imposed hard constraints on Argentine government policy for a full decade after its implementation in 1991 and before its abandonment in 2001, public support for this tight restraint (perceived as responsible for taming inflation) remained firm, and support for democracy was fairly high in Argentina by regional standards in 1995–96. Levels of satisfaction with the performance of the market economy understandably plunged after unemployment continued to be high and the banking system collapsed, taking with it many families' life savings. In 2002, a mere 2 percent of Argentines were satisfied with the functioning of the market. But even amid tightly constrained macroeconomic policy and rising poverty, ordinary Argentines continued to support democratic governance; support for democracy remained steady at high levels by regional standards. In 2002, voters turned to Nestor Kirchner, who campaigned against the neoliberal model and IMF policies, but who represented the most important Argentine political party – the Peronists.

The other question to address is whether the openness to the world economy emblematic of globalization affects citizen support for democracy. El Salvador and Mexico are among the most open economies in Latin America; their trade as a percentage of GDP is in the same range as Chile (roughly 55 percent) (Table 11.5), but both are doing reasonably well in terms of citizen support for democracy. Such a finding is consistent with work that has shown that public confidence levels have remained high in some of the smaller Trilateral democracies (i.e., those most dependent on the global economy and most affected by internationalization or globalization) (Katzenstein 2000) – at least if they continue to provide protection against the risks that follow from exposure to trade. In our Latin American sample, trade openness is not significantly correlated with market satisfaction or support for democracy. There is also no correlation between openness to capital markets and foreign investment and citizen support for democracy.

Although globalization, understood as increased trade and capital flows, and neoliberalism are often used interchangeably in the popular (and especially opposition) discourse, they are distinct phenomena. Given higher levels of public support for globalization than for state retrenchment, it is possible that not globalization, but neoliberal state reform, might erode support for democracy. Satisfaction with the quality of public services narrowly misses a statistically significant correlation with the composite index of citizen support for democracy. To explore this hypothesis more fully, we would want to consider whether opposition to neoliberalism is evident at the polls.

From Opinions to Votes

It is almost a truism that the people in Latin America won't stand for neoliberalism. Reality is more complicated. Latin American voters have shown that they

TABLE 11.5. *Globalization and Economic Openness: Latin America*

	Trade Openness ^a	Net Private Capital Flows (% GDP)	Foreign Direct Investment (% GDP)	Capital Account Liberalization Index ^b (1995)
Argentina	17.5	6.2	4.3	0.99
Bolivia	36.8	11.6	9.2	0.89
Brazil	23.2	9.1	6.5	0.64
Chile	54.8	7.6	5.8	0.75
Colombia	30.4	3.8	2.8	0.73
Costa Rica	28.3	3.8	2.5	1.0
El Salvador	56.5	2.4	1.3	0.92
Guatemala	39.1	.9	1.1	0.95
Mexico	54.2	1.9	2.2	0.88
Peru	29.2	2.9	1.3	0.91
Uruguay	71.6	3.1	1.6	0.84
Venezuela	37.0	4.4	3.6	0.93
Latin America		6.2		

^a Trade openness represents the sum of exports plus imports expressed as a percentage of GDP.

^b The capital account (or international financial) liberalization index represents the average of four components, which reflect the sector control of foreign investment; limits on profit and interest repatriation; controls on external credits by national borrowers; and capital outflows. The index is normalized to be between zero and one, with one being the most reformed or free from distortion or government intervention. The difference between each country's "raw" index and the least liberalized country observation is expressed as a percentage of the difference between the maximum and minimum observations for all the countries over the entire period from 1970 to 1995. The maximum value of the index is the level actually attained in Costa Rica in 1990 and 1995 (Morley, Machado, and Pettinato 1999: 11, 9).

Sources: World Bank (2003: 238–41); Morley et al. (1999: 32).

are willing to mete out punishment for sluggish growth, high unemployment, and declining real income – as they did quite dramatically in Mexico in 1988. When economic reforms seem to work, however, they tend to reward incumbents. The reelection of Carlos Menem (1995), Alberto Fujimori (1995), and Fernando Henrique Cardoso (1998) may be attributable to the success of their governments in controlling inflation. In this volume, Martín Tanaka attributes Fujimori's ability to build a coalition to consolidate his power to his timely control of inflation. Mayorga credits the success of the Paz Estenssoro administration's NEP (New Economic Policy) in stabilizing the Bolivian economy and later generating an economic recovery with helping to solidify and legitimize the Bolivian democratic regime. These elections demonstrate a growing political sophistication on the part of Latin American voters.

The success of neoliberal reforms may be especially important when voters feel deceived. Stokes (2001) finds that although voters tend to support a government that changes course in office from what it promised in its electoral campaign when outcomes are sufficiently good, as they were in Argentina under Carlos Menem, they abandon a government that does the same when the

outcomes of unmandated policies are bad, and this is what she contends happened in Venezuela. The outcome of elections may also be sealed by the ability of governments to focus voters on issue areas other than the one where the government imposed unmandated policies. In Peru, the Fujimori government successfully diverted attention from the economy to peace and rallied support by defeating the Shining Path guerrilla rebellion and embarking on a spending program just before election time. At minimum, the impact of economic constraints on democracy are complicated and probably attenuated by the way they are presented (a point Moisés Naím [1993] made about Venezuela under Carlos Andres Pérez), and perceived.

The process by which reform is generated, and the results of reform, can also be significant. Drawing from the Polish experience, Adam Przeworski argued that when reforms are ushered in by stealth by insulated technocrats, when, in other words, policy makers circumvent representative institutions in order to speed the reform process, the public “learns” that important decisions are made outside the framework of representative institutions. “Repeated surveys show that people do not see the locus of power in the properly constituted institutions. . . . If decisions are made elsewhere, representative institutions wilt” (Przeworski 1995: 80–82). Although the Argentine case is often cited as an example of reform by presidential decree, Levitsky points out – correctly – in his chapter that after the first year of his government, Menem consulted widely with Congress, which had significant influence over the package of economic reforms (a point reinforced by Corrales 2002). He sees the strength of the (Peronist) Justicialista Party (PJ) as facilitating smooth executive–legislative relations. As he rightly points out, Argentina combined economic liberalization and democracy in a way that was unparalleled in Latin America. Among fully democratic cases (e.g., Costa Rica, Uruguay, Venezuela, and Brazil), Argentina’s economic reforms were more rapid and far-reaching, and among cases of deep crisis and radical reform (i.e., Chile, Mexico, and Peru), Argentina’s regime was the most democratic. Even Bolivia under Paz Estenssoro relied on a stage of siege and harsh labor repression.

Finally, globalization is perceived to have destabilized democracies in two ways: by creating economic dislocation and by engendering a cultural reaction as people struggle to maintain their distinctive national, religious, and ethnic identities – in the words of one popular writer, they fight for their “olive trees” (Friedman 2000). This claim may assume greater salience in the Andean region, where ethnic grievances have come to the fore in recent years. In Bolivia, Evo Morales’s Movement to Socialism won 21 percent of the vote in the 2002 election, and the Pachakutik party of Felipe Quispe won another 6 percent; together, they captured 33 percent of the seats in the lower Chamber (*The Economist* 2004: 36). Although Deborah Yashar has downplayed the impact of globalization, per se, on the emergence of ethnic movements and political parties in Ecuador and Bolivia, she does attribute great weight to the redefinition of rights and representation that has accompanied neoliberal economic reforms (Yashar 2005).

Citizen Expectations and Government Performance

Our second thesis was that citizen disillusion with democracy might be attributable to a gap between government *performance* and what citizens *expect* of government. If citizen expectations are unrealistically high, something that scholars feared in the 1980s as democratic governments were poised to inherit bankrupt states and promissory notes to citizens deprived of material well-being – as well as freedom – by authoritarian regimes, it could result that no government could match inflated and unrealistic expectations. Supporting such a view, Malone, Baviskar, and Manel (2003: 23) find that the higher that citizens in Argentina, Brazil, Chile, and Guatemala rank what they call the “all-embracing” elements of democracy (in an ideal democracy, public security is maintained, the well-being of citizens is protected, all citizens have access to education and health care, no one goes hungry, and everyone has work and a minimal standard of living), the *less likely* they are to support democracy unequivocally (i.e., respond that “democracy is preferable to any other form of government”). They find that the gap between expectations and performance is substantially wider in the newer democracies of Latin America than in the established democracies of Germany, Denmark, and the United States (2003: 20).

If expectations are important in explaining citizens’ declining confidence, so, too, is performance. For Newton and Norris (2000: 72), the performance of governments and political institutions is critical, and several authors in this volume highlight the performance side of the equation. Reflecting on the rather sudden erosion of the democratic regime in Bolivia after 2000, Mayorga called attention to the fact that democratic governments in Bolivia have performed poorly, and have been unable to meet the socioeconomic expectations of a poverty-ridden country – with 65 percent of all urban jobs in the informal sector, two thirds of the population being poor, and persistently low levels of education, health, and nutrition. Mainwaring and Pérez-Liñán contend that poor government performance since 1992 is perhaps the single most important variable accounting for democratic erosion in the region. Indeed, the record of democratic governments has been dramatically poor in several key areas. In 2003, 225 million Latin Americans had incomes that fell below the poverty line (UNDP 2004), leading the UNDP to conclude: “Slow economic growth, profound inequalities, and ineffective legal systems and social services are triggering popular unrest and undermining confidence in electoral democracy.”

Many authors treat citizen expectations of government as general. But might poor performance in some areas weigh more heavily in public dissatisfaction with and indifference toward democracy than overall macroeconomic stability and growth, as Naím (1993) poignantly argued was the case in Venezuela in 1991 when the economy grew by 10 percent, but an angry public penalized their government nonetheless for a sharp deterioration in the quality of public services? With the advantage of more sophisticated polling of public opinion in Latin America than ever before, we can reasonably accurately identify those problems that citizens perceive are important and that government is

not handling well at any given time. A volume on Latin American democracy appearing in the late 1980s would undoubtedly have highlighted inflation as public enemy number one. With inflation generally under control across the continent by the late 1990s (Table 1.12), that issue is no longer cited by survey respondents as one of the most urgent facing their families, their localities, or their countries.

In recent years, three issues have topped the charts (Table 11.6). The first is *economic security*, understood principally as unemployment and secondarily as poverty. To a more limited extent, some citizens also expressed concern with “economic crisis,” and real incomes and the cost of living, indicating that the desire for a well-paying job is a far more salient concern today than inflation and even overall growth rates. Although growth and employment are surely related, “jobless recoveries” do exist. The second major policy area is *public security*, especially violent crime but sometimes including drug trafficking, gangs, and guerrillas. The third most salient issue is *corruption*. Access to quality social services (health and education) is less salient. I examine the first three areas in turn. Although perceptions about corruption could color evaluations of government performance in managing the economy and providing order – that is, citizens might penalize governments more if they attribute the performance-expectations gap to malfeasance rather than structural constraints, wrong policies, or even mere incompetence – I treat corruption as a separate issue.

Economic Security

Alesina and Wacziarg (2000) place great emphasis on government performance in the areas of growth, inflation, and unemployment. Because they are explaining a secular trend over the course of a half century, they are most interested in the dramatic drop-off in the performance of governments in the Trilateral Democracies before and after the 1973–74 oil shock. Prior to this, growth was more robust, inflation was lower, and unemployment rates were more modest. After the oil shock, the reverse was true in each area.

In Latin America, it is also true that growth was more robust in the period prior to 1974, when world trade expanded and commodity prices for Latin America’s main exports were high. Certainly the 1980s are considered the “lost decade” in Latin America, so called because standards of living at the end of the decade were lower than they were at the beginning, and in most countries equal to levels in 1970. In other words, economic contraction in the 1980s eroded the gains produced by growth in the 1970s. At the same time, inflation in the 1980s was extraordinarily high, fueled by the astronomical burden of debt service.

In the 1990s, things generally turned around. Inflation rates fell to rates lower than they had been even during the period of growth in the Second Wave democracies. In Argentina, Peru, Brazil, and elsewhere, voters tended in the Third Wave to reward governments that could impose price stability. But on the other hand, unemployment has risen in most countries with scant signs of abating.

TABLE 11.6. *Most Salient Problems in Twelve Latin American Countries (percent responding most important problem facing country or sum of responses)*

Country	Date of Poll	Economic Security				Personal Security		Access to Social Services		Government/ Corruption
		Unemployment	Poverty	Economic Crisis	Cost of Living/Wages	Public Security/Crime	Specific Problems	Health	Education	
Argentina	May 2003	82(1)	27(4)			39(2)		22(5)	29(3)	
Bolivia	Dec. 2003	63(1)	45(3)							57(2)
Brazil	Dec. 2002	63(1)				35(4)	41(2) ^a	41(2)		
Chile	Jan. 2002	63(1)	45(3)							57(2)
Colombia	Dec. 2003	40(1)					24(3) ^b			29(2)
Costa Rica	Oct.–Dec. 2002	18(2)	8(5)	11(4)	19(1)	16(3)	8(6) ^a			
El Salvador	Nov.–Dec. 2003	22(1)	19(3)	15(4)		22(1)	8(5) ^c			
Guatemala	Oct. 2001	16(2)			40(1)	18(3, 4) ^d				
Mexico	Feb. 2004	22(2)	15(3)	24(1)	13(4)					7(5)
Peru	Aug. 2003	24(1)	13(4)	21(2)		7(6) ^e				15(3)
Uruguay	Jan. 2004	44(1)		13(2)	9(5)					22(3, 4) ^f
Venezuela	Aug. 2003	38(1)			15(2)	15(2)				

^a Drugs. ^b Guerrillas. ^c Gangs.

^d “Common crime,” was cited by 11 percent of respondents, and “violence in general,” by 7 percent.

^e The fifth most important problem was a “crisis of values,” cited by 9 percent of respondents.

^f “The executive does not govern well” was cited by 12 percent of respondents, and “Congress does not function; politicians don’t agree,” by 10 percent.

Sources:

Argentina: Ipsos-Mora y Araujo (2003). Based on a national sample of 1,200 cases.

Bolivia: Encuestas & Estudios (2003). Based on a sample of 1,500 urban and rural residents.

Brazil: IBOPE (2002). Based on a nationwide sample of 2,000 adults.

Chile: Centro de Estudios Públicos (2002).

Colombia: *Revista Semana* (2004).

Costa Rica: Latin American Public Opinion Project, Vanderbilt University (2002). Based on a national sample of 1,016 adults.

El Salvador: IUDOP (2003).

Guatemala: ASIES (2001). I am grateful to Dinorah Azpuru for making these data available.

Mexico: Consulta Mitofsky (2004). Based on a sample of 1,200 adults over the age of 18.

Peru: Grupo de Opinión Pública de la Universidad de Lima (2003). Based on a sample of 518 persons in Lima-Callao.

Uruguay: Cifra/González, Raga y Asociados (2004). Based on a sample of urban areas with more than 2,000 inhabitants.

Venezuela: Alfredo Keller y Asociados (2003). Based on a national sample of 1,200 and groups in twelve cities.

In one recent survey, 54 percent of Latin Americans – *not counting those who are already unemployed* – expressed concern that they will be left without work or become unemployed during the next twelve months (Table 11.7).

What has been the impact on elections and democracy of persistent government impotence in generating employment? In the years from 1982 to 1990, Remmer (1991b) found that crisis conditions, as indicated by inflation, economic growth, and exchange rate depreciation, undermined support for incumbents and provoked high levels of electoral volatility, but without necessarily fostering growth of political extremism or exhaustion of the elite consensus for democracy. But how long the pass to failing democratic governments and the era of good feeling following from the victory over inflation lasts is not clear. Perhaps predictably, in Argentina, voters turned out the Peronist government that had conquered hyperinflation (and even recorded a 50 percent expansion of the economy in the early 1990s) after unemployment rose above 17 percent and stayed there. On the other hand, in this volume Magaloni argues that in Mexico voting trends are not strongly correlated with economic growth. The PRI recovered surprising support in the worst years of the recession of the 1980s (when the economy grew on average by only 0.5 percent per year and real minimum wages and average industrial wages lost around 75 percent and 35 percent of their value, respectively), and in 1997 and 2000, the PRI was punished at the polls despite an improvement in growth rates to 2.9 percent per year. Venezuela's severe economic decline (from 1993 to 2002, the economy shrank by 18 percent and urban unemployment averaged 20 percent, the worst performance in Latin America [Table 1.12]) certainly contributed to the collapse of the Venezuelan party system, but Coppedge argues that this powerful political effect was unusual. As he puts it, rising unemployment, falling real incomes, and even economic contraction, as was true in Venezuela, may result in the rejection of an incumbent government or party at the polls, but not typically in a grave crisis of the democratic regime. Consistent with Magaloni and Coppedge's insights, neither rates of unemployment nor economic growth are significantly correlated with the index of citizen perceptions of democracy.

Along with growth, inflation, and unemployment, particularly in Latin America, looms the question of inequality. Inequality in Latin America has worsened over the course of the Third Wave, probably as a result of both stagnant economies and neoliberal reforms. Might persistent inequality be a cause for public disaffection from democracy in societies where disparities in wealth and life chances are as dramatic as they are anywhere in the world, as suggested recently by *The Economist* (2004)? Here, the aggregate evidence is inconclusive. Two countries in our sample with among the most severe inequalities in the world – Brazil and Guatemala (along with South Africa) – display quite different levels of composite support for democracy.

Public Security and Crime

In several Latin American countries, crime and violence are serious problems and highly salient political issues. The case of Colombia, where the state has

TABLE 11.7. *Popular Experience with Salient Problem: Latin America, 2003*

	Fear of Unemployment ^a	Victim of Crime ^b	Drug Consumption ^c	Satisfaction with Access to Health	Satisfaction with Access to Education	Awareness of Corruption ^d	Progress in Reducing Corruption in State Institutions ^e
Argentina	55	42	19	48	52	19	26
Bolivia	57	31	9		52	20	17
Brazil	63	36	41	38	50	56	28
Chile	40	34	19		43	6	36
Colombia	57	36	18		54	11	57
Costa Rica	47	33	31		74	18	—
El Salvador	60	39	14	51	58	20	24
Guatemala	66	32	11	42	49	10	10
Mexico	53	60	57		58	53	29
Peru	50	37	15		21	14	24
Uruguay	40	26	10		57	11	36
Venezuela	59	44	29	44	56	23	22
Latin America	54	36	21		49	21	28

Notes:

^a Q. How concerned would you say you are that you will be left without work or unemployed during the next 12 months? Very concerned, concerned, a little concerned, or not at all concerned? Percent responding “very concerned” and “concerned.”

^b Q. Have you, or someone in your family, been assaulted, attacked, or been the victim of a crime in the past 12 months? Percent responding “yes.”

^c Q. Have you known if any of your friends or someone in your family has consumed drugs in the past 12 months. Percent responding “yes.”

^d Q. Have you, or someone you know, been aware of an act of corruption in the past 12 months? Percent responding “yes.”

^e Q. How much do you think that there has been progress in reducing corruption in state institutions during the last two years? Percent responding “a lot” and “some.”

Source: Latinobarómetro (2003: 10, 51, 52, 50, 30).

clearly failed to exercise a monopoly on violence in society, particularly stands out in this respect. In their chapter, Bejarano and Pizarro argue that the capacity of the Colombian state to control its jurisdiction contracted over the course of two decades in favor of armed groups on both the left and right, and the state even abdicated some of its functions and power to right-wing organizations like the United Self-Defense Forces of Colombia. Their evidence is persuasive: Paramilitary groups operated in 40 percent of all Colombian municipalities, and hundreds of mayors, members of parliament and departmental assemblies, and other public officials were assassinated in the decade from 1989 to 1999. Tragically, there have been half a million violent deaths in the past twenty years.

Where citizens crave security against violence, they clearly have cause to lose faith in the effectiveness of their governments. In his chapter, Mitchell Seligson brings to our attention a recent paper by Nancy Bermeo about the breakdown of democracy in interwar Europe, a time in which, like in the Third Wave of democratization in Latin America, “never before had so many citizens in so many nations been accorded so many formal rights” (Bermeo 2003: 21). Revising the conventional wisdom that rampant inflation and economic depression caused fragile democracies to crack wide open, Bermeo (1999, cited in Seligson, this volume) contends that what distinguishes the surviving democracies from those that collapsed is the crime rate. Her data show that from 1920 to 1938 in democracies that broke down, homicides (the least underreported crime) occurred at three times the rate of the surviving democracies.

Against this backdrop, the data reported by Seligson (this volume) are sobering: According to the United Nations Global Report on Crime, the estimated homicide rate in Latin America is 30 per 100,000, compared to 7 per 100,000 in the United States (the rate in those European countries in which democracy broke down in the interwar period), and 2 per 100,000 today in the United Kingdom, Spain, and Switzerland. Guatemala’s homicide rate – 58.68 per 100,000 – is at a level eight times higher than in the European democracies that broke down in the 1920s and 1930s, and fifty times higher than in the ones that survived. Wood reports that El Salvador’s homicide rate in 1994 and 1995 was an astronomically high 138 per 100,000. The significance of this figure – the world’s highest along with Colombia (80 per 100,000 in 1991) and South Africa – can perhaps best be appreciated by contrasting it to the prewar rate (33 per 100,000), and the rate in 1982 (at the height of the war) – 55.3. According to the IADB (Inter-American Development Bank), crime victimization more generally is higher in Guatemala and El Salvador than in any of the other Latin American countries. In 1998, 25.7 percent of Salvadorans polled reported that their families had been victims of an assault in the previous four months. In public opinion surveys since 1994, more Salvadorans judged crime to be the principal problem facing the country, more so than any other issue, including the economy. The Salvadoran case is not unique. Across the region, more than one third of Latin Americans (and 60 percent of Mexicans) in 2003 reported that they or someone in their family had been the victim of a crime in the previous twelve months (Table 11.7).

When citizens perceive their (democratic) governors cannot handle a serious problem, they look elsewhere. One possibility is the military. Public support for the military's role in fighting crime is overwhelming: Seligson's data from the 1999 University of Pittsburgh survey show 79 percent of the Guatemalan population supported this role (this volume). He speculates that high levels of crime could stimulate support for restrictions on civil liberties, a speculation that is well supported by a disturbing pattern of rising support for the *mano dura* (strong-hand government) over the "participation of everyone" as a means of solving the country's problems. Support for the *mano dura* rose from 48 percent of respondents in 1993 to 60 percent in 1999, while those who favored broad participation shrunk from 40 percent in 1993 to 29 percent in 1999. Seventy percent of respondents preferred order to rights. More starkly, in 1999, 55 percent of Salvadorans stated that crime would justify a coup (Wood, this volume). Another possibility is to take "justice" into their own hands: One of the most disturbing trends in the otherwise salutary move toward democracy in Central America has been the spread of mob justice to close the public security gap. "Lynchings" – not hangings, per se, but more frequently death by immolation or mob beatings – have become problematic in El Salvador and rampant in Guatemala (Mendoza and Torres-Rivas 2003). From 1996 to 2000, there were 337 lynchings in Guatemala, with a total of 185 deaths, and 448 persons were wounded for a total of 635 victims (Seligson, this volume). In the Pittsburgh surveys reported by Seligson, 29 percent of Guatemalans approved of the lynchings, and 12 percent approved of the lynchings some of the time; only just under half of respondents always rejected this practice.

The Salience of Corruption

At the same time that new entrants to the political arena may wish greater outputs of government – cheaper goods, neighborhoods free of drug dealers and gangs, access to quality health care, better schools for their kids, a real roof over their heads – citizens also generally wish for cleaner government. They want to know that public officials, from chief executives and government ministers to the local police officer on the block, are not skimming off the public purse. Susan Pharr (2000) found that misconduct in office is a far more powerful predictor of Japanese confidence levels over the past two decades than a number of other possible causes. Both *actual* and *perceived* levels of corruption may be important. Actual corruption may be responsible for worsening government performance, thus reducing trust in government's capacity to address citizens' demands, as Donatella della Porta (2000) shows is true in the Trilateral democracies. Perceptions of corruption could be at least as important in that they shape citizens' views about their democracies and their democratic institutions as much as or more than the reality.

Does corruption, as widely presumed, indeed erode trust in government or destabilize democracy? By one measure, voting, it is not at all clear that citizens turn to antisystem options when they perceive their officials are corrupt. In one recent study, Seawright (2004: 25–27) finds that in the two cases when voters

abandoned established political parties in droves and destabilized democracy – Peru and Venezuela – at the aggregate level, perceptions of corruption were only in the upper third of all countries included in the 1995–97 World Values Survey, and not as high as in other countries such as Argentina where democracy has fared much better. At the individual level, he finds that voters who believed corruption to be prevalent abandoned the governing party in favor of candidacies he calls “insurgent” only in the 1990 local elections; in the 1983 presidential election, they tended to reject the incumbent Social Christian (COPEI) party but to the benefit of its established opposition, the Acción Democrática (AD), and in 1998, perceptions of corruption appear to have played no role in voters’ decisions to vote for or against the traditional parties (Seawright 2004: 36).

The timing of the “corruption penalty” in Venezuelan elections, and the targeted beneficiaries suggest that the corruption penalty may have been applied to the traditional parties in sequence. It is also entirely possible, as Michael Coppedge suggests in his chapter, that there is an interaction effect between perceptions about corruption and economic performance. If economic performance explains no more than about a third of the vote shift away from the traditional parties, as Seawright argues, Coppedge’s identification of corruption as a “magnifying condition” becomes highly relevant. Coppedge argues (p. 314) that corruption “can magnify the impact of economic performance enough to make a big difference [in a country’s political regime] in a short time. . . . Citizens can tolerate corruption if the economy is growing rapidly, and they can tolerate a contraction if they believe their representatives have done everything possible to prevent it or stop it. But when a contraction coincides with known corruption, the political consequences are magnified.” For Coppedge, this was how Venezuelans understood economic decline: Venezuelans believed that their country was rich, and that corruption was rampant. In this volume (p. 311) he writes, “Poll after poll showed Venezuelans blaming the economic crisis on waste and corruption rather than the debt or falling oil prices. . . . A large percentage of Venezuelans came to believe that the economy declined because the politicians had stolen from the patrimony of a fundamentally rich country.” The key for Coppedge is that the two major parties – the AD and COPEI – tolerated corruption, institutionalized impunity, and permitted corruption to become commonplace and widespread. They protected their own and each other’s members and made punishment the rare exception for alleged corruption – at least until the early 1990s. Impunity also had the effect of making corruption less tolerable.

The link between perceptions of corruption and support for democracy, however intuitive, has not been an easy one to establish empirically (see Seligson 2001: 92–93 for a discussion of the claims advanced in World Bank papers in recent years). Such a link needs to be made at the individual level, which requires appropriate survey data. Based on such surveys, Seligson (2001: 115–16) did find evidence in Bolivia of an inverse relationship between having been a victim of corruption and support for democracy; higher rates of victimization were correlated with higher levels of support for an authoritarian regime and

government *de mano dura*, and with lower levels of satisfaction with democracy. This finding was replicated in El Salvador, Nicaragua, and Paraguay¹¹ (Seligson 2002: 424).

With strong reason to believe that high levels of corruption erode support for the legitimacy of the political system, we would want to know how severe the problem of corruption is perceived to be in Latin America in recent years. One fifth of Latin Americans (21 percent) claim to have been aware of an act of corruption in the preceding twelve months, or know someone who was (Table 11.7). Again, the countries that are perceived to be the least corrupt are those we consider to have the strongest democracies – Chile, Costa Rica, and Uruguay. Of the nine cases studied in this volume, Brazil and Peru receive the highest scores from both Transparency International (Table 1.12) and the World Bank Global Governance Indicators project (Table 11.2), with the greater improvement in Brazil. Mexico, Colombia, El Salvador, and Argentina follow, and of these, Argentina shows the most precipitous decline, suggesting that more corruption scandals have come to light in Argentina in recent years. Venezuela, Guatemala, and Bolivia are perceived to be the most corrupt; in these, democracy is perceived by many scholars to be fragile.

Is there, then, a strong link between perceptions about corruption and support for democracy? Much more research is clearly needed. Our cases and research suggest that the answer may depend on the interaction of corruption with economic performance, whether corruption is perceived to be grand theft – a spectacular gain on the part of a president (such as Collor de Mello) or simply “malfeasance” (the charge against Carlos Andres Perez) – or widely practiced on a petty level by government bureaucrats and police officers, and especially whether or not citizens care. In Brazil in 2002, corruption was cited as only the sixth most important problems facing the new Lula government, behind unemployment, health, drugs, public security, and inflation, despite the fact that more Brazilians (56 percent of respondents) showed awareness in the most recent Latinobarómetro poll of an act of corruption in the preceding twelve months than any other country (Table 11.7). Similarly, Mexicans, who also were aware of corruption in high numbers, did not identify the issue as salient. By contrast, Chileans, with the most favorable Transparency International rating in the region and the lowest public experience with corruption, rated corruption as the second most important problem facing the country. Most telling, the identification of corruption as one of the most serious problems facing the country among Bolivians rose from 14 percent of respondents to a

¹¹ This survey consisted of 2,914 randomly selected interviews in El Salvador, 2,410 in Nicaragua, 2,970 in Bolivia, and 1,463 in Paraguay. All fell into the bottom half of countries on Transparency International's corruption index (Salvador, 49th; Nicaragua, 70th; Bolivia, 80th; and Paraguay, 90th). Experiences with corruption were ascertained by responses to a battery of eight questions that asked if the respondent had been stopped by a police officer and asked to pay a bribe, had observed a bribe being paid to a police officer or public official, or had been asked to pay a bribe to a public office, municipal government, place of work, or the court system (Seligson 2002: 418–19).

national poll in January 1995 to 57 percent of 1500 respondents in December 2003 (Encuestas & Estudios 2003), just two months after Sánchez de Lozada's ouster.

In sum, the relationship between faltering government performance and loss of support for democracy is strong but certainly not perfectly linear. Unemployment has been as high in Argentina and Uruguay in the past decade as anywhere in Latin America except for Venezuela and Colombia, but democracy in these countries appears to be about as solid as can reasonably be expected. We have known at least since the Great Depression – when a ravaged German economy paved the way for Nazism but equally dire circumstances in the United States and Sweden did not – that political systems can navigate perilous economic waters or sink in them. Dizzying crime rates and levels of violence have been more threatening to democracy in Guatemala and Colombia than in El Salvador. Corruption appears to erode public confidence in democracy, but on its own cannot accurately predict the loss of public support for democratic institutions. Something, then, mediates the effects of inadequate government performance in some countries, and insulates others from truly spectacular crises. What prompts citizens to look the other way, to trust their government and their leaders?

WHEN DO CITIZENS FORGIVE POOR GOVERNMENT PERFORMANCE? THE ELUSIVE DIMENSION OF POLITICAL REPRESENTATION

In his chapter on Argentina, Steven Levitsky attributes the surprising success of the Menem government in maintaining Argentine democracy, even amid 20 percent unemployment, to a layer of political representation that socialized citizens, cushioned the blows of deprivation, and organized consent. He contrasts Argentina to Peru, where the reservoir of Peronist organizations was not present, and where the sole political party to survive – Alianza Popular Revolucionaria Americana (APRA; American Popular Revolutionary Alliance) – never had that reach into the countryside. Levitsky's evidence is compelling and his argument is persuasive. In his detailed surveys of Peronist unions and neighborhoods in the late 1990s, he found that more than 80 percent of national unions, and more than 90 percent of local unions, participated in Justicialista Party (PJ) activities. He also found that the PJ maintained close ties to a range of other civic and social organizations. In 1997, more than half of 112 local party branches maintained ties to civil associations, clubs, or other social organizations, and more than a third possessed ties to at least two such organizations. Levitsky's survey found 96 percent of local PJ branches engaged in some form of social assistance: Nearly 70 percent of these local branches distributed food or medicine, and more than half regularly organized child care and tutoring services, as well as social and cultural activities in their neighborhoods. Slightly less than half offered programs for the elderly. Levitsky's research is consistent with that of Auyero (2000), who found that neighborhood-level Peronist "problem solving networks" interceded with state authorities to obtain wheelchairs,

disability pensions, scholarships, funeral expenses, and odd jobs for their constituents. The PJ's strong ties to working- and lower-class society, Levitsky argues, prevented the sort of mass urban looting and protest over economic reforms witnessed elsewhere in Latin America in the 1990s, and it helped the PJ to retain its traditional and lower-class electorate in the 1990s, even amid soaring rates of unemployment, which in turn served to limit the prospects for the sorts of antireform and antisystem appeals that took hold in other countries. Such prospects were real, not hypothetical, in the Argentine case: The electoral challenge of Movement for Dignity and Independence (MODIN; Movimiento por la Dignidad y la Independencia), which had seemed viable in 1994, collapsed in 1995. As Levitsky correctly points out, even Front for a Country in Solidarity (Frente por un País Solidario; FREPASO) drew primarily middle-class, not lower-class support.

To generalize such a promising argument is difficult. We must first of all be able to recognize a network when we see one, and most scholars have not engaged in the kind of fieldwork that Levitsky and Auyero have conducted in Argentina. In their place, we may rely on the density of party networks or even membership in organizations of civil society, but we would have no way of knowing how vibrant or moribund such organizations really are. We would also need to know what *kind* of networks of representation are most effective in bonding citizens to their democratic institutions. Some linkages may be more effective and enduring than others. At times, networks that deliver to citizens particularistic benefits – be they patronage, goodies from the pork-barrel, clientelism and social assistance, or even resolution of personal problems with the bureaucracy – can be especially effective in organizing consent, and at other times, parties that rely on these compensation mechanisms may find themselves suffering massive voter rejection at the polls. In other contexts, networks that allow for genuine popular participation in real decision making may be more resilient. It is not at all clear that networks based on compensation and participation are interchangeable from the standpoint of democratic stability, especially since networks that allow for genuine participation may be more difficult for governments to manage.

In order for connections to preserve citizen trust in government and support for democracy, must they be personal? On the one hand, the contemporary debate about “social capital” suggests that the answer should be yes. On the other, a long tradition in political science that focuses on the responsiveness and accountability of representatives to citizens suggests that if parties offer ideologies, programs, or policies that conform to voters' wishes, they may continue to enjoy citizen support, even in the absence of personal attention, particularistic benefits, and social ties, whereas if they do not, they may suffer electoral penalty, even if these are offered. This discussion adds a wrinkle to the unresolved Huntington–Putnam debate. If civil society organizations can either buttress parties or, as Berman (1997) has shown was true of Weimar Germany, compete with them and even undermine democracy, then is a well-mobilized civil society an asset for democracy *independent* of the strength of

political parties and partisan–citizen linkages, or is it beneficial for democracy only when it is anchored to strong political parties?

To begin, let us consider first the impact of the unmediated mobilization of civil society on democracy. Levitsky assigns great weight to the flourishing of Argentine civil society *as a counterweight to state authority* in the preservation of Argentine democracy. He credits not merely or especially the organized labor movement, which was always strong in Argentina, but also the “second-wave” human rights-oriented organizations and Argentina’s print and electronic media with providing the sort of societal accountability that held regional and national governments to account for the deaths of the Catamarcan teenager María Soledad Morales (cf. Smulovitz and Peruzzotti 2003) and the investigative journalist José Luiz Cabezas. Civil society also blossomed in Brazil during the Third Wave of democratization; indeed, this may be one of the most dramatic differences distinguishing Brazil’s contemporary democracy from its postwar variant. Weyland acknowledges that both trade union density and participation in voluntary associations is rising in Brazil. In one recent survey, two thirds of respondents reported membership in voluntary associations, a percentage that is significantly higher than that of Spain (McDonough et al. 1998). Some of these organizations contribute to local and state-level decision making through the practice of “participatory budgeting,” an experiment that originally took shape in southern Brazil and that has since been emulated elsewhere in Brazil and abroad as one of the most vibrant democratic experiments of the Third Wave. Political participation may be more widespread, independent, and active in Brazil today than it has ever been.

There is also evidence that social organizations served as schools of democracy in war-torn El Salvador. Citing surveys conducted by Seligson and Córdova Macías in 1995, Wood reports that participation in municipal meetings was much higher in areas in which the Farabundo Martí National Liberation Front had been active than elsewhere. Residents of FMLN zones were also more politically tolerant, attended municipal meetings at a much higher rate, and characterized municipal services – even where they were seriously deficient – more favorably than other groups. In an area of Usulután in which Wood did her own field research, where *campesinos* had supported the FMLN during the war, networks of activists continue to organize collectively and bargain with various agencies and non-governmental organizations over the terms of development assistance.

One of the most important contemporary claims about the import of the independent association of citizens in civil society and civic involvement is that it builds “social capital” (Putnam 1993), the social ties and trust that make governments more effective and responsive to their constituents. Newton and Norris (2000: 72) find that “aggregate level social trust and confidence in government and its institutions are strongly associated with each other.” Their claim is that social trust can help build effective social and political institutions, which can help governments perform effectively, and this in turn encourages confidence in civic institutions.

TABLE 11.8. *Interpersonal Trust, Trust in Government, Trust in Political Institutions: Latin America, 2003*

	Interpersonal ^a	Political Parties ^b	Vote for a Political Party ^c	Government ^b	Recovering Credibility ^d
Argentina	17	8	44	45	59
Bolivia	21	6	46	14	47
Brazil	4	16	44	42	66
Chile	10	13	45	46	39
Colombia	13	9	31	33	34
Costa Rica	11	10	39	23	46
El Salvador	12	11	42	21	50
Guatemala	18	8	22	7	39
Mexico	19	10	55	24	65
Peru	15	8	40	14	54
Uruguay	36	18	53	19	48
Venezuela	13	14	47	28	53
Latin America	17	11	42	24	49

Notes:

^a Q. Generally speaking, would you say that you can trust most people, or that you can never be too careful when dealing with others? Percent responding "You can trust most people."

^b Q. Please look at this card and tell me how much confidence you have in each of the following groups/institutions. Would you say you have a lot, some, a little, or no confidence? Political Parties. Government. Percent responding "A lot" and "Some."

^c Q. If elections were held this Sunday, which party would you vote for? (Percent responses that mention a political party.)

^d Q. Some people say politics and politicians have lost credibility and it seems like they cannot recover it. Other people say that politics depends on the people that are in charge and each one has the opportunity to recover that credibility. Percent responding "Politics depends on the people that are in charge and each one has the opportunity to recover that credibility."

Source: Latinobarómetro (2003: 27, 47, 46, 40, 48).

In Latin America, it is not at all clear that interpersonal trust engenders greater trust in government and political institutions. The highest rates of interpersonal trust in the 2003 Latinobarómetro poll were registered in Uruguay (Table 11.8), where 36 percent of those surveyed responded "You can trust most people," followed by Bolivia (21 percent), Mexico (19 percent), and Guatemala (18 percent). Both Bolivia and Guatemala have large indigenous populations, and it is possible that the dimension of interpersonal trust is capturing communal solidarities. Yet, Guatemala and Bolivia (along with Peru) had the lowest levels of trust in government (only 7 and 14 percent, respectively). Conversely, Brazil and Chile, two of the three countries with the highest levels of trust in government (along with Argentina), where 46 and 45 percent of respondents, respectively, expressed a lot of or some confidence in government, had the lowest levels of interpersonal trust (4 and 10 percent, respectively). With less than one fourth the level of interpersonal trust, Brazilians placed six times more trust in government than Guatemalans. In fact, the correlation

between interpersonal trust and trust in government is negative and not significant.

Similarly, there is no apparent link between interpersonal trust and trust in political parties. Latin Americans generally exhibit little trust in political parties, though such low scores are fairly typical in comparative terms. In a recent survey, the percentage of citizens trusting political parties in Austria, Korea, the Czech Republic, and Russia were 17, 21, 15, and 7 percent, respectively (Rose and Shin 2001: 345). Having said this, there are intraregional differences. In 2003, the lowest rate of trust in parties was registered in Bolivia (where only 6 percent of the population expressed trust in parties), Peru, Guatemala, and Argentina (where 8 percent did so) – countries with relatively high rates of interpersonal trust (Table 11.8). At the opposite end of the spectrum, the highest rates were recorded in Uruguay and Brazil (18 and 16 percent, respectively). Brazilians had twice the level of trust in political parties and were twice as likely to be able to identify a party for which they intended to vote as Guatemalans, who exhibited more than four times more interpersonal trust. Although Uruguayans had nine times the level of interpersonal trust that the Brazilians did, they had nearly the same level of trust in political parties (Table 11.8). Although Brazilians exhibited the lowest levels of interpersonal trust in Latin America, by far, they were also the most willing to concede that politicians had the opportunity to recover their credibility (Table 11.8). Two thirds agreed that such a recovery was possible.

If interpersonal trust predicts little about trust in political institutions, then we should ask more precise questions about the conditions under which social organizations are linked to political representatives in ways that strengthen democracy.¹² In particular, we would want to return to the question of whether civil society should be connected to political parties, and whether democracy is healthier when it is. Here, our authors offer divergent answers. Levitsky is quite clear in the importance he attaches to the continuing strength of political parties in Argentina in accounting for the resilience of Argentine democracy. In his chapter on Brazil, Kurt Weyland views civil society in precisely the opposite way. For Weyland, Brazil's democracy survives because it is of "low quality." People make few demands, or few demands that can be met by government, so the potential supporters of an authoritarian order are satisfied to let democracy ride. Because we know that membership in organizations is high, his argument hinges on the incapacity of Brazilian civil society to voice effectively its demands that government redress inequality. Weyland insists that Brazilian civil society is fragmented in ways that make coordinated, class-based action

¹² Robert Fishman (2004: 107), drawing from extensive survey research in a number of Spanish towns and cities, has recently argued that mere membership in any social organizations, what he calls *total organizations*, is not nearly as productive a concept as membership in *useful organizations*, those identified by respondents as useful in pursuing collective objectives. Useful organizations exert a far greater impact on what he calls "globally discursive horizons," or, the capacity of cities and citizens to transcend the defense of specific local interests and instead address more widely experienced problems and processes.

in favor of redistributive policies difficult. The labor movement is divided between the more radical Central Única dos Trabalhadores (CUT) and the more moderate Força Sindical, which mitigates class conflict, and the popular sectors are divided and weakened by pronounced organizational fragmentation. But crucially, he also sees (p. 105) parties as lacking firm links with social groups, which “disables the main institutional mechanism that could in principle advance bottom-up pressure for a systemic transformation.” Thus mass poverty and egregious social inequality do not translate into open political contention.

René Mayorga’s analysis of Bolivian society straddles both sides of this debate. On the one hand, he speaks of the decline of labor union influence in Bolivia in much the same way that Weyland does for Brazil and that Carlos Waisman (1992) did in describing the effect of the weakening of the Argentine labor movement in the 1980s for Argentina’s economic and political recovery and its escape from the destructive cycle of the preceding Peronist era. For Mayorga, the practical elimination of the Bolivian Workers’ Confederation (Central Obrera Boliviana; COB) (which had an ambiguous commitment to democracy) as a political actor and as an agent of political representation for the popular classes, and the erosion of corporatist, class-based interest representation served to attenuate political conflict in Bolivia. In this respect, Mayorga joins the view that a well-organized civil society can overload government, throttle economic reforms, and frighten elites to the point that they seek out antidemocratic alliances.

But another way to read Mayorga is that the most dangerous development in Bolivia has been a mobilized civil society that is unconnected to, deeply disenchanted with, and certainly not represented by political parties. In Mayorga’s account, the capacity of Bolivian political parties to serve as mediating structures and to articulate and aggregate the demands of the sectors that did not benefit from economic development – to represent them – declined during the administration of Hugo Banzer. The best evidence of this, for Mayorga, was the politicization of social conflicts during Banzer’s term, and the constant, direct confrontation between the state and contentious social actors. The leading edge of civil society today is the peasant movements of Chapare and the Northern Altiplano, represented by ethnic leaders Evo Morales and Felipe Quispe, which reject the “party monopoly of politics” (as well as the neoliberal model) in favor of a “fuzzy model” of participatory democracy in which popular organizations and social movements intervene directly in state affairs and exert corporatist mechanisms of social control over the state administration.

This discussion returns us to the starring role of political parties in securing representative democracy. If most scholars and aid agencies are already persuaded of the value of a vibrant civil society, they are now becoming aware that political parties are allowed to rot at democracy’s peril. The recent United Nations project on citizens’ democracy (UNDP 2004) highlighted that 59 percent of 231 political leaders interviewed (including almost all sitting presidents and living former presidents in Latin America) lamented that political parties are failing to fulfill their necessary role. Where citizens trust parties and believe

they can recover their credibility, support for democracy across a series of measures is stronger. What keeps parties vibrant as representatives of citizens?

The Latin American cases examined in this volume point in two directions. One is for parties to maintain effective linkages with social organizations, or to be inclusive. When parties were linked to social organizations in Venezuela, democracy was by all accounts quite robust (Levine 1973), but when these links frayed, Venezuelan democracy was left quite hollow and defenseless when oil prices fell and belts had to be tightened. Recent events in Brazil confirm such a view. The 2002 vote for Lula in the presidential election cannot be viewed as an expression of distrust in traditional parties and a vote for an insurgent, or antisystem, party and candidate – turnover rates in the legislative elections were very similar to the past, and while the Partido dos Trabalhadores (PT; Workers' Party) gained some seats, the partisan balance in the legislature was not noticeably upset, and gubernatorial elections confirmed the stature of governors of the Party of Brazilian Social Democracy (Partido da Social Democracia Brasileira; PSDB) and the Party of the Liberal Front (Partido de Frente Liberal; PFL). Arguably, the PT succeeded where other parties of the “establishment left” in Latin America failed because of the party's close connections, built up over a course of two decades, with Brazil's civic organizations. In this feature of Argentina's party–civil society relations may lie the key to its democratic overachievement.

A second key to party effectiveness may be the representation of policy alternatives. Seawright (2004) argues that party system collapse in Peru and Venezuela was a product of genuine policy divergence between traditional parties and the electorate. If we continue with the logic of this argument, we may note that where there are more partisan policy differences and more real opportunities for parties on both the left and right to gain local and national power than ever before, democracy may be more robust. This may be especially evident in Mexico, where serious political contenders have emerged to the left *and* right of the PRI, and El Salvador, where the left has gained in electoral strength since the first post–civil war elections. Uruguayan democracy is also arguably more responsive and flexible for having moved from a two-party system of the traditional Colorados and Blancos to a three-party system now including the leftist Frente Amplio. The Brazilian party system is also stronger not merely because of the growing strength of the PT but also because parties more generally are decidedly stronger than their reputation.

The new mix of parties in these countries raises the question of what is the “right” degree of partisan difference and electoral change. Obviously, in order for new alternatives to emerge and become electorally viable, there must inevitably result a certain degree of polarization and volatility, two conditions that ordinarily cause concern among political scientists. Rising rates of electoral volatility can be a sure sign that something is amiss in a party system: The massive rejection of Venezuela's COPEI and Peruvian political parties in the mid-1990s, for example, constitutes perhaps our best indication that something was terribly wrong with democracy in these countries. Also, persistently high

rates of volatility may signal a failure of a new, stable party system to take root. On the other hand, opening up parties and political systems to new actors may be precisely what keeps them vibrant, and moderate volatility for a delimited period may be a salutary development for democracy if it permits a party system to realign and develop new partisan options. Venezuela's low electoral volatility in the 1980s may have concealed voter frustration, which led first to the rise of Causa R and other third-party alternatives, and eventually to Hugo Chávez's Bolivarian movement. To his supporters, Chávez may have given voice to long-standing frustrations, and despite Chávez's apparent disregard for Venezuela's democratic institutions, Venezuelans evince reasonably high levels of support for democracy. And Chileans, who do not value their democracy to nearly the same degree that we would expect given the highest scores on democratic governance of any country in Latin America, may be bristling precisely at the narrowing of the scope of partisan policy difference on key issues since the transition to democracy.¹³ The party that has performed well in recent years, the Independent Democratic Union (Unión Demócrata Independiente; UDI), has staked out clear positions on the far right of the political spectrum and established close connections with citizens at the grassroots level.

In sum, the weight of the evidence in this volume suggests that over the long haul, a robust civil society, given links to political institutions and a chance to participate, may serve as the best inoculation that democracy has against disappointing economic performance, especially when caused by exogenous shocks. There is an inherent danger in basing legitimacy on performance, as every exdictator knows. Where political representation is weak, the survival of governments is dependent on performance, and poor performance may erode democratic regimes, as evidenced in Haiti, Paraguay, Ecuador, and Peru. Even given a similar set of economic problems, democracy has remained more solid in those countries that can count on mature – or maturing – networks of political association, participation, and representation. Where layers of political representation effectively texture the political process, democracy today appears stronger than where these layers have frayed or never existed. Of course, it is very possible that I have reversed the causal arrows, and that declining performance erodes trust in parties, which severs these connections. But that is a question for further research.

¹³ In the mid-1990s, Juan Linz and Alfred Stepan (1996: 222–23) attributed the relatively low and declining levels of support for democracy in Chile (in 1995, 52.2 percent of Chileans agreed that democracy was preferable to any other form of government, down from 63.8 percent in 1991) to “the *incompleteness* of the Chilean transition, the . . . place of the military in Chilean . . . society . . . , and the constraints under which Chilean democracy has been operating.” Given the movement toward the resolution of the role of the military since the arrest in Britain of Augusto Pinochet, it seems plausible that we consider further the nature of the perceived constraints on Chilean democracy. Ideological polarization, or the distance between the ideological self-placement of members of the leftmost and rightmost parties (the Socialists and the Independent Democratic Union), is fairly narrow in comparative terms (Martínez Rodríguez 1998: 61), and party positions are fairly close on the most important economic issues of the day.

CONCLUSIONS

This chapter began by asking why in the past quarter century democracy has endured longer in Latin America than ever before, and, under those circumstances, why it appears to be so poorly supported by its own citizens. In contrast with earlier eras, when ordinary Latin Americans struggled for the rights and benefits of citizenship, mass publics today appear disaffected, disenchanted, and, at times, even available to support politicians whose democratic credentials are dubious at best. With the benefit of the contributions to this volume, the first question was relatively simple to address: International support for democracy, value change among Latin American elites and the left, the fracture of the civil-military alliance, the narrowing of the scope for redistributive measures that has accompanied the adoption of neoliberal economic policies, and the reform of political institutions have maintained the momentum of a wave that might have otherwise crashed like those that came before.

Explaining the gradual and sporadic receding of this wave, however, is more difficult. Unlike in other contexts, in Latin America in the Third Wave, support for democracy is nearly impossible to predict, interpersonal trust is not strongly associated with trust in government and political institutions, and globalization and neoliberalism have not condemned democracy to a poor quality of life, as alleged. We should not be daunted by a lack of fit between comparative trends and the politics of Latin America's Third Wave. Regime change in Latin America has previously informed comparative theories about political regimes and the sources of their stability and instability, teaching us that democracy in middle-income countries can break down (O'Donnell 1973) and that authoritarian regimes can fall apart, not because of structural conditions but because of strategic splits within ruling circles (O'Donnell and Schmitter 1986). Latin American cases have also instructed us that the Roman Catholic Church can be a force for democracy, and that militaries can be tamed. In the best tradition of Latin American politics, we should use the experience of the Third Wave democracies in the region in the past quarter century as a window on how citizens evaluate their governments and their democracies.

This volume has highlighted the relationship between faltering government performance and the erosion of public support for democracy. We are not the first to do so. The shortcomings of government in responding to citizen needs are widely known in Latin America and the United States among elites, mass publics, international aid agencies, and the academic community. For international aid agencies, the solution is perceived to be to empower civil society to perform a watchdog role. For some academics, the solution is to insulate decision makers, attenuate polarization and conflict, and inoculate governments from populist pressures that can only derail governments from pursuing the tough but correct policies. Yet a third approach has been to reform political institutions. It is now apparent that these approaches taken individually cannot stabilize the rapidly shifting sands on which Latin American democracy is standing.

The relationship between faltering government performance and the erosion of the Third Wave of democratization is expressed in declining public support for democracy. But this erosion is not directly linear. In this chapter, I have suggested that the key variable mediating the relationship between government performance and citizen attachment to democracy is the nature and quality of political representation, and specifically, the linkages between citizens, civic organizations, and political parties. In making this argument, I have undoubtedly raised many more questions than I have resolved. Nonetheless, if this volume sparks more analysis of individual level attitudes and behavior and more research on the connection between citizens and national political institutions in this era of mass democracy, it will have made an important contribution. And if this analysis turns out to be correct, as we go forward we should bear in mind that the various strands of political representation are worth connecting, and the networks themselves are worth deepening and extending, if mass democracy is to survive in hard times like ours.